

An Introductory Word

Scripture Reading: Zech. 1:1-6

With this message we begin the life-study of Zechariah.

I. The status of Zechariah

A. The grandson of Iddo and the son of Berechiah

Zechariah was the grandson of Iddo and the son of Berechiah (Zech. 1:1). In Hebrew the name Iddo means "at an appointed time"; the name Berechiah means "Jehovah will bless"; and the name Zechariah means "Jehovah will remember." Hence, the total significance of these three names is that at an appointed time Jehovah will bless and Jehovah will remember.

B. Born of a priestly family in captivity and becoming a prophet who returned to Judah

Zechariah was born of a priestly family in captivity (Neh. 12:1, 4, 12, 16). He was first a priest, and then he became a prophet. He returned to Judah with Zerubbabel at the time of the prophet Haggai (about 520 B.C.). Zechariah and Haggai encouraged the building of the temple of God under the hands of Zerubbabel and Joshua. Joshua was the high priest, representing the priesthood, and Zerubbabel, a descendant of the royal family, was the governor of Judah, representing the kingship. Thus, the kingship went forth with the priesthood and built the temple of God. Even today in the building up of the church as the Body of Christ, we need both the priesthood and the kingship.

II. The time and place of Zechariah's ministry

The time of Zechariah's ministry was from the second year of Darius Hystaspis (different from both the Darius in Daniel 9:1 and 11:1 and the one in Nehemiah 12:22). The year was about 520 B.C. The place of Zechariah's ministry was Judah (Zech. 7:3-4).

III. The opening word

The book of Zechariah opens with a word exhorting the children of Israel to return to Jehovah with the promise that Jehovah will return to them (1:2-6). They had returned from Babylon to Jerusalem, but probably most of them had not returned to the Lord. Verse 3 says, "Return to Me, declares Jehovah of hosts, and I will return to you, says Jehovah of hosts." Here we have a principle: first we have to return to the Lord, and then the Lord will return to us.

IV. The subject of Zechariah's prophecy

The subject of the prophecy of Zechariah is Jehovah's hearty consolation and promise to His chastised chosen people through the redemption of Christ, who in His humiliation became their suffering Companion in their captivity.

V. The central thought of Zechariah's prophecy

The central thought of Zechariah's prophecy is that Jehovah remembers His chastised people and sympathizes with them in their suffering of the nations' excessive reaction to His punishment over them. For their suffering of His punishment, God sent Christ as His Angel to be with them and go with them through their captivity, who accomplished a fine redemption for their salvation. In the meantime Jehovah also raised up "craftsmen" to deal with the nations who had reacted in excess. He also gave a hearty word of consolation and promise through Zechariah, a prophet of restoration, saying that He would bring the scattered Israel back to their own country with the expectation of a time of restoration and prosperity.

In this central thought there are several important factors: God's sympathy, redemption, salvation, the Savior, the Redeemer, and the Deliverer. Because of His sympathy, God came in to console the people whom He had chastised. In this consoling work, Christ was sent to accomplish redemption for their salvation, making Christ their Savior as well as their Redeemer. In God's redemption for salvation, Christ is the centrality. Christ came the first time to redeem God's elect by being crucified and shedding His blood. His coming the second time will not be to redeem but to deliver God's elect out of the hand of Antichrist and to bring in a time of restoration and prosperity. Thus Christ is also the Deliverer, making Christ the universality. In this universe we see Christ on the cross as the center, and from that center Christ is spreading Himself to the circumference. This is the universality of Christ. Ephesians tells us that this redeeming Christ who produced the Body, the church, is the One who fills all in all (1:22-23). He is surely the centrality and the universality in God's plan and in God's redemption.

VI. A comparison between the prophets Isaiah, Daniel, and Zechariah

We need to make a comparison between the three prophets, Isaiah, Daniel, and Zechariah, in two matters: in God's economy toward His chosen people and in Christ for the people of His concern.

A. In God's economy toward His chosen people

1. In Isaiah

Concerning God's economy toward His chosen people, Isaiah reveals that all the nations are for God's chosen people either positively or negatively. God's real concern is for Israel, and all the nations are utilized by God for Israel's benefit, both positively and negatively. For example, Babylon under Nebuchadnezzar was used in a negative way, whereas Medo-Persia under Cyrus was used in a positive way. Cyrus was chosen by God and was His delight. God regarded him as the shepherd of His people in their captivity.

2. In Daniel

In Daniel all the nations are sovereignly under God's heavenly ruling for Israel to be God's witness and testimony on earth. Satan used Nebuchadnezzar to destroy Judah and to carry the Jews into captivity in Babylon. Satan's intention was to end God's testimony on earth with all His witnesses. But he did not realize that among these captives God had four young overcomers. Whatever Satan would do, these overcomers had a way to counter it and annul it. They overcame the demonic diet, the devilish blinding, and the seduction of idol worship. All of Satan's devices merely resulted in God's testimony being strengthened and uplifted through His young overcomers. Eventually, the authority to govern the land of Babylon was in the hands of Daniel and his three companions.

3. In Zechariah

In Zechariah all the nations' dealings with Israel are for Israel to experience Christ in their ignorance. God's concern for Israel is seen in His dealings with all the nations.

B. In Christ for the people of God's concern

1. In Isaiah

The book of Isaiah unveils Christ in many items, mainly concerning Christ's being, that is, concerning what Christ is. Regarding Christ for the people of God's concern, in Isaiah we see that Christ is ushered in as the all-inclusive One to meet the need of the chastised Israel and of the judged nations. God is so merciful in His dealing to bring in Christ not only for Israel but also for the nations. Hence, Christ is the Savior not only of Israel but also of all the nations.

2. In Daniel

The book of Daniel reveals that Christ is the excellent One who came to be crucified for the producing of the new creation to match Him as His bride and who will come back with His bride to terminate the human government and replace it with God's eternal kingdom. In Daniel we see that Christ in His crucifixion is the landmark between God's old creation and God's new creation. In His appearing to the prophet, He was the excellent and precious One for the appreciation and expectation of the people of God. In His appearing to the human powers on the earth, He will end the human government and become the divine kingdom throughout the whole earth for eternity.

3. In Zechariah

In Zechariah we see that Christ as the sent One from God is with God's suffering people to be their Redeemer. We also see that in His humiliation He goes with them through their suffering to be their Savior in a fine and sympathetic way.

The book of Zechariah does not stress Christ's being or His working. Rather, it reveals Christ as the One who was sent to Israel as their King in a lowly form but was detested, sold, attacked, and pierced, and thereby accomplished redemption for them. Christ as the Angel of Jehovah was with them in their captivity. Eventually, Christ will fight for Israel and will be King over all the earth.

VII. The sections of this book

A. The introductory word

The first section of the book of Zechariah is the introductory word in 1:1-6.

B. The visions of consolation and promise

The second section of Zechariah consists of the visions of consolation and promise (1:7—6:15). These visions include the vision of a man as the Angel of Jehovah riding on a red horse and standing among the myrtle trees in the bottoms of the valley (1:7-17); the vision of the four horns and the four craftsmen (1:18-21); the vision of a man with a measuring line in His hand (ch. 2); the vision of Joshua the high priest perfected, established, and strengthened by the Angel of Jehovah with Zerubbabel the governor of Judah (ch. 3); the vision of the lampstand of gold and two olive trees, one to its right and one to its left (ch. 4); the vision of the flying scroll (5:1-4); the vision of the ephah vessel (5:5-11); the vision of the four chariots (6:1-8); and the concluding word to confirm the eight visions by the crowning of Joshua as a type of Christ, who will build the temple of God and will hold two offices — the priesthood and the kingship — in peace on His throne (6:9-15).

C. The advice to Israel and the desire of Jehovah to restore Israel

The next section (chs. 7—8) consists of the advice to Israel to turn from the vanity of their ritualistic religion to the reality of a godly life, and the desire of Jehovah to restore Israel.

D. The prophecies of encouragement centered on Christ

The last section (chs. 9—14) covers the prophecies of encouragement centered on Christ. These prophecies include the prophecy concerning the nations around Judah in relation to Israel (ch. 9); the prophecy concerning the Lord's loving visitation to Israel (ch. 10); the prophecy concerning the living of Israel under the oppression of the Roman Empire (ch. 11); and the prophecy concerning Israel's destiny in the great war of Armageddon, in their household salvation, and in the millennium (chs. 12—14)

The Visions of Consolation and Promise

(1)

Scripture Reading: Zech. 1:7-21

In this message we will consider the two visions of consolation and encouragement in 1:7-21. Both of these visions are strong consolations with sweet promises of expectation to the suffering Israel.

I. The vision of a man as the Angel of Jehovah riding on a red horse and standing among the myrtle trees in the bottoms of the valley

A. A man

Verse 8a says, "I saw during the night, and behold, a man was riding upon a red horse." This Man is Christ in His humanity. To Daniel, this Man was excellent; to Zechariah, He was very sympathetic.

B. The Angel of Jehovah

The Man here is the Angel of Jehovah (v. 11a). The Angel of Jehovah is Jehovah Himself as the Triune God (Exo. 3:2a, 4-6, 13-15). The Angel of Jehovah is also Christ as the embodiment of the Triune God (Col. 2:9) and as the sent One of God (John 5:36-38; 6:38-39). The Angel of Jehovah is also the Angel of God who escorted and protected Israel on their way from Egypt to the promised land (Exo. 23:20; 32:34; Judg. 6:19-24; Isa. 63:9).

C. Riding on a red horse

The Man in this vision is riding on a red horse (Zech. 1:8a). In Revelation 6 the red horse signifies war, which always involves bloodshed, but here the red horse signifies Christ's swift move in His redemption by the shedding of His blood.

D. The myrtle trees

Verse 8b says, "He was standing among the myrtle trees that were in the bottoms." These myrtle trees signify the humiliated people of Israel in their captivity.

E. Standing among the myrtle trees in the bottoms of the valley

As Christ was riding on a red horse, He was standing among the myrtle trees that were in the bottoms of the valley. This means that He remained strongly among the captured Israel in the lowest part of the valley in their humiliation. Captured Israel was in the lowest part of the valley, and Christ was ready to do anything for them swiftly. Christ, the One on the red horse, was their patron taking care of them in their captivity.

F. Behind the Angel of Jehovah, there being red, reddish-brown, and white horses

"Behind Him there were red, reddish-brown, and white horses" (v. 8c). Christ was riding on a red horse, and following Him were horses of three different colors. This indicates that Christ's redemption (the red horse) leads the repentant Israel (the reddish-brown horses) to be justified and accepted by God swiftly (the white horses). Although they were the redeemed people of God (the red horses), as the reddish-brown horses indicate, they were not that pure but were a mixture. The word reddish indicates redemption, and the word brown indicates a mixture. Eventually, as signified by the white horses, when the redeemed people of God come to God and are dealt with, they will be justified.

This vision of the horses portrays the situation of Israel in their captivity. In the eyes of God, Christ the Redeemer was with them taking the lead, and they, God's redeemed people, were following Him. Because they were God's redeemed people, they appear at first sight as red horses. But because they were not pure, they are signified also by the reddish-brown horses. They need to contact God and to be dealt with by Him in order to gain God and be justified by Him and thus become those signified by the white horses. Once they repent, they will swiftly be accepted by God and justified by Him.

G. The red, reddish-brown, and white horses having been sent by Jehovah to go to and fro on the earth

"Then I said, What are these, sir? And the angel who spoke with me said to me, I will show you what these are. And the man who stood among the myrtle trees answered and said, These are those whom Jehovah has sent to go to and fro on the earth. And they answered the Angel of Jehovah who was standing among the myrtle trees, and they said, We have gone to and fro on the earth, and behold, all the earth sits still and is quiet" (vv. 9-11). Here we see that the red, reddish-brown, and white horses, signifying those among Israel who were to be redeemed and brought back to God for His justification and acceptance, had been sent by Jehovah to go to and fro on the earth; and they answered the Angel of Jehovah standing among the myrtle trees that they had gone to and fro on the earth and had seen that all the earth sat still and was quiet.

These verses reveal that in addition to Christ, who had been sent as the Redeemer to take care of Israel in their captivity, others had been sent by God to go through the earth to see the situation of the nations. As indicated by the movement of the horses, God's captured people were unsettled and were without peace, rest, and the enjoyment of life. The nations, on the contrary, were sitting still and quiet. This indicates that, in the eyes of God, all the nations around Israel at that time were sitting there enjoying their life in peace and quietness while God's elect were suffering.

H. The Angel of Jehovah interceding

In verse 12 we see that the Angel of Jehovah interceded for Israel. "Then the Angel of Jehovah answered and said, O Jehovah of hosts, how long will You not have compassion on Jerusalem and on the cities of Judah, with which You have been indignant for these seventy years?"

I. Jehovah answering the angel who spoke with Zechariah

In verses 13 through 17 we have Jehovah's answer to Christ's intercession for Israel. Jehovah answered the angel who spoke to Zechariah with good words, with comforting words, and the angel said to him, "Cry out, saying, Thus says Jehovah of hosts: I am greatly jealous for Jerusalem and for Zion" (v. 14). Because the nations were sitting peacefully while Jerusalem was in trouble, Jehovah was very jealous for Jerusalem. He was extremely angry with the nations, who were at ease, sitting still and quiet (v. 15a). He was only a little angry with Israel, but the nations dealt with Israel excessively (v. 15b).

Verse 16 goes on to say, "Therefore thus says Jehovah, I return to Jerusalem with compassions; My house will be built in it, declares Jehovah of hosts, and a measuring line will be stretched over Jerusalem." To measure is to possess. For Jehovah to cause a measuring line to be stretched over Jerusalem means that He will possess that city. For seventy years Jerusalem was given up by God. Now He was coming back to repossess the city, so He sent someone to measure it. In verse 17 Jehovah went on to say, "My cities will again overflow with good, and Jehovah will again comfort Zion and will again choose Jerusalem." This is the way Christ's prayer for Israel was answered by God.

II. The vision of the four horns and the four craftsmen

In verses 18 through 21 we have the vision of the four horns and the four craftsmen.

A. An answer to Christ's intercession

This vision was the answer to Christ's intercession for Zion and Jerusalem (vv. 12-17).

B. The four horns

"Then I lifted up my eyes and saw, and behold, there were four horns. And I said to the angel who spoke with me, What are these? And he said to me, These are the horns that have scattered Judah, Israel, and Jerusalem" (vv. 18-19). These four horns are the four kingdoms with their kings — Babylon, Medo-Persia, Greece, and the Roman Empire — signified by the great human image in Daniel 2 and by the four beasts in Daniel 7:3-8, which damaged and destroyed the chosen people of God.

C. The four craftsmen

"Then Jehovah showed me four craftsmen. And I said, What do these come to do? And he spoke, saying, These are the horns that have so scattered Judah that no man lifts up his head, but these have come to terrify them, to cast down the horns of the nations who have lifted up the horn against the land of Judah to scatter it" (vv. 20-21). These four craftsmen are the skills, including the stone not hewn by man's hands, used by God to destroy the four kingdoms, with their kings, that destroyed the nation of Israel. Christ is the One among the craftsmen who will come as the stone cut out without hands to smash the great image.

Each of the first three kingdoms — Babylon, Medo-Persia, and Greece — was taken over in a skillful way by the kingdom which followed it. Babylon was defeated in one night when Darius the Mede came and defeated Belshazzar. How skillful was Darius! Then, as Daniel 8 reveals, the goat from Macedonia (the Grecian Empire under Alexander the Great) came to trample the ram of Persia. History tells us that Alexander the Great was very skillful. He was one of the craftsmen that dealt with the four horns. Later the Roman Empire came in to deal with Greece. These four empires are the central factors of human history. Eventually, the restored Roman Empire will be smashed into powder by Christ as the top Craftsman.

All four empires devastated and destroyed Israel. But they all have been or, in the case of the restored Roman Empire, will be destroyed by the four craftsmen raised up by God. This is a comforting and encouraging word of promise.

The Visions of Consolation and Promise

(2)

Scripture Reading: Zech. 2

In this message we come to chapter two of Zechariah, which is a very mysterious chapter.

III. The vision of a Man with a measuring line in His hand

In this chapter Zechariah saw a vision of a Man with a measuring line in His hand. "I lifted up my eyes and I saw, and behold, there was a Man, and in His hand was a measuring line. And I said, Where are you going? And He said to me, To measure Jerusalem; to see how great its breadth is and how great its length is" (vv. 1-2).

A. A Man

This Man is Christ in His humanity as the Angel of Jehovah, the One speaking with Zechariah (vv. 1a, 2-3a; cf. Ezek. 40:3; Zech. 1:9-11).

B. A measuring line

The measuring line (2:1b) signifies measuring in order to possess. For example, when we buy land or cloth, we may first measure its length and width. After we measure the land or the cloth, we then proceed to possess it.

C. To measure Jerusalem

The Man with the measuring line intended to measure Jerusalem for the purpose that Jehovah may repossess it (Zech. 2:2, 4b). Jerusalem was given up by God for the seventy years of captivity. After the captivity, God came back to Jerusalem to measure it for His possession. This measuring is not only to know the size but also to know the condition and the situation. The measuring was done by a Man, not by an angel. An angel is unqualified to measure anything human, because he does not have the human nature. Only Jesus, who has both the divine nature and the human nature, is qualified to measure Jerusalem.

Whereas the temple is the sign of God's house, the city of Jerusalem is a sign of God's kingdom for His administration. The city of Jerusalem was measured and was found to be without limit (v. 4). This indicates that the size of God's kingdom is the size of God Himself. Therefore, the measuring has revealed two important matters: that God's kingdom is unlimited and that God Himself is the size of His kingdom.

D. Her wall of fire round about and the glory within her

"I will be her wall of fire round about, declares Jehovah, and I will be the glory within her" (v. 5). Here we see that the wall of the city of Jerusalem and the glory within her are Jehovah Himself, indicating that Jehovah will be the protection of Jerusalem at her circumference and her glory at her center. Both the glory in the center and the fire at the circumference are Christ. This shows the centrality and universality of Christ in God's economy. Today Christ is the glory in the center of the church, and He is also the fire burning around the circumference of the church for her protection. In the New Jerusalem the Triune God in Christ will be the glory at its center (Rev. 21:23; 22:1, 5), and this glory will shine through the transparent wall to be its protection of fire (Rev. 21:18).

E. The crucial significance of this vision to the people of Zion

Zechariah 2:6-13 tells us the crucial significance of this vision to the people of Zion.

1. Jehovah having spread them out like the four winds of the heavens

In verse 6b Jehovah declares concerning His people, "I have spread you out like the four winds of the heavens." We may think that God scattered the people of Israel when they were taken into captivity. However, this verse says not that God scattered them but that He spread them. This is like the spreading of the believers in Acts 8. Thousands of believers were in Jerusalem, but God was not satisfied. A persecution was raised up which scattered them. That persecution was not good, but it brought in a glorious spreading (Acts 11:19). Likewise, if the children of Israel had not been captured, God's testimony would have been limited to the small city of Jerusalem with its temple. But when the children of Israel were scattered to Babylon, four young people became witnesses of God and a testimony for Him. In this way, God's testimony was spread to Babylon. If God's testimony had not come to Babylon, how could people realize that He is able to make the fire in the blazing furnace of none effect and able also to shut the mouths of lions? God is great and sovereign, and He has a broad heart. Therefore, He wanted His testimony to be spread to faraway places.

2. Jehovah wanting them to flee from the land of the north to escape

"Ho! Ho! Flee from the land of the north, declares Jehovah....Ho, Zion! Escape, you who dwell with the daughter of Babylon" (Zech. 2:6a, 7). Here we see that God wanted His people to leave Babylon and come back to the holy land.

3. Christ as the One sent by Jehovah of hosts and as the Sender, Jehovah of hosts

Verse 8 says, "Thus says Jehovah of hosts, After the glory He has sent Me against the nations who plunder you; for he who touches you touches what is in the pupil of His eye." What is meant by the expression "after the glory"? It refers to after the return of the captives. In the seventy years of captivity, the glory was absent from the center of Jerusalem. But when the children of Israel returned to Jerusalem, the glory also returned. Although Joshua and Zerubbabel were godly, many of the others who returned to Jerusalem from Babylon were not. Nevertheless, in the sight of God, their return was a glory. Therefore, "after the glory" means "after the return."

The first part of verse 8 says, "Thus says Jehovah of hosts, After the glory He has sent Me." Who is the He, and who is the Me? The He refers to God, Jehovah of hosts, and the Me refers also to Jehovah of hosts. Jehovah of hosts sent Jehovah of hosts. This means that Jehovah of hosts is the Sender and the One sent.

In the Old Testament, Jehovah is a divine title that refers to the Triune God. This is revealed in Exodus 3, where we see that Jehovah is the God of Abraham, the God of Isaac, and the God of Jacob. Although there is a distinction between the God of Abraham and the God of Isaac and also between the God of Isaac and the God of Jacob, this does not mean that there are three Gods. To say that there are three Gods is to fall into the heresy of tritheism. God is triune — the Father, the Son, and the Spirit. Ephesians 1 tells us that God the Father chose and predestinated us, that God the Son redeemed us, and that God the Spirit sealed us. Thus we have the choosing and predestinating Father with the redeeming Son and the sealing Spirit. This is the Triune God, the three-one God. The word triune is composed of the Latin tri, meaning three, and une, meaning one; hence, three-one. We have one God, the unique God, but He is three-one.

The Father, the Son, and the Spirit are not three separate Gods but three "hypostases...of the one same undivided and indivisible" God (Philip Schaff). The Greek word for hypostasis, the singular form of hypostases, is composed of two Greek words: hupo meaning "under" or "below" and stasis meaning "substantial support." Hence, hypostasis refers to a support under, a support beneath, that is, something underneath that supports, a supporting substance. The Father, the Son, and the Spirit are the hypostases, the supporting substances, that compose the one Godhead.

In Zechariah 2:8 one of the three in the Godhead sent another of the three. The Sender is called He, and the sent One is called Me. Surely the He refers to the Father, and the Me, to the Son. After the glory, the Triune God decided to do something marvelous. The decision was that the Father would send the Son. This corresponds to what is revealed in John 5 and 6. "He who does not honor the Son does not honor the Father who sent Him" (5:23). "I do not seek My own will but the will of Him who sent Me" (v. 30). "The works which the Father has given Me to finish, the works themselves which I do, testify concerning Me that the Father has sent Me" (v. 36b). "The Father who sent Me, He has testified concerning Me" (v. 37a). "I have come down from heaven not to do My own will but the will of Him who sent Me" (6:38). "No one can come to Me unless the Father who sent Me draws him" (v. 44a). "The living Father has sent Me" (v. 57a). Zechariah 2 and John 5 and 6 all speak of the Father's sending the Son. Both the Father and the Son are Jehovah.

Christ as the One sent by Jehovah of hosts and as the Sender, Jehovah of hosts, will be against the nations who plunder the people of Zion and touch them as the pupil of His eye. Our eyes are extremely sensitive and immediately react to anything that touches them. "His eye" refers to the Father's eye. God's people are very dear to Him, and whoever touches them touches the pupil of His eye. This was a word of comfort, encouragement, and consolation to Zerubbabel, Joshua, and all the other returned ones.

Zechariah 2:9 goes on to say, "For I am now waving My hand over them, and they will be plunder for those who served them; and you will know that Jehovah of hosts has sent Me." Here we see again that Jehovah of hosts sent Jehovah of hosts.

4. The rejoicing of the daughter of Zion

In verse 10 the daughter of Zion is commanded to give a ringing shout and rejoice, for now Jehovah is coming and will dwell in their midst. The I in this verse is the same One as the He and the Me in verses 8 and 9.

5. Many nations joining themselves to Jehovah and becoming His people

Many nations will join themselves to Jehovah and will become His people. He will dwell in the midst of Zion, and Zion will know that Jehovah of hosts has sent Him to them (v. 11). In this verse, once again both the I and the Me refer to Jehovah.

6. Jehovah inheriting Judah as His portion

Jehovah will inherit Judah as His portion upon the holy land, and He will again choose Jerusalem (v. 12).

7. All flesh hushing themselves before Jehovah

Verse 13 says, "Hush, all flesh, before Jehovah! For He is roused up from His holy habitation." Before the glory returned to Jerusalem, Jehovah was silent. But after the glory He was roused up from His holy habitation. All flesh — including the flesh of the Babylonians, Persians, Greeks, and Romans — must be silent. Only Jehovah has the right to speak, and only He is the deciding factor. Today our Triune God is no longer silent in His heavenly habitation. He is moving, working, and doing things in the church. This indicates that the glory is here in the church. The measuring brings in such a glory that we all must hush and allow the Lord alone to speak.

The Visions of Consolation and Promise

(3)

Scripture Reading: Zech. 3

In this message we will consider the vision of consolation and promise in Zechariah 3. This vision is for the strengthening and assuring of the returned captives regarding the rebuilding of the temple of God in their distress.

IV. The vision of Joshua the high priest perfected, established, and strengthened by the Angel of Jehovah with Zerubbabel the Governor of Judah

In the first four chapters of Zechariah, the Angel of Jehovah is taking care of five visions. This implies that Christ as God's sent One is always with God's people taking care of them. In chapter three we have a vision showing us that Joshua the high priest was perfected, established, and strengthened by the Angel of Jehovah with Zerubbabel the governor of Judah. Joshua, a most important leader among God's people, was under the care of the Angel of Jehovah. The way the Angel of Jehovah took care of Joshua was to measure him. Thus, the measuring in chapter two is continued in chapter three. Christ came to measure Joshua and thereby to take care of him.

A. The Angel showing Zechariah Joshua the High Priest

The Angel showed Zechariah Joshua the high priest (v. 1a). Joshua typifies Christ as the High Priest sent by God to His people (Heb. 3:1; 4:14-15; 7:26). Joshua represents and signifies Israel as a nation of priests (Zech. 8:20-23; Isa. 2:2-4a).

B. Standing before the Angel of Jehovah to be perfected, established, and strengthened

Joshua was standing before the Angel of Jehovah to be perfected, established, and strengthened (Zech. 3:1-10). The Angel of Jehovah would do this by measuring him. Therefore, Joshua stood before the Angel of Jehovah for the purpose of being measured by Him.

1. Resisted by Satan standing at his right hand

While Joshua was standing before the Angel of Jehovah, he was resisted by Satan, who was standing at his right hand to accuse him (v. 1b). The word Satan means "the accuser," "the adversary," and it is the base for the word accuse at the end of verse 1. An adversary is an inward enemy. For example, if someone outside your family opposes you, that person will be your enemy. But if a member of your family opposes you, that person will be your adversary. Such an adversary is a more serious threat than an enemy. As the adversary, Satan's intention was to put Joshua down in front of his fellows (v. 8) and to frustrate the rebuilding of God's temple.

2. Jehovah's defense extended to him

Verse 2 says, "And Jehovah said to Satan, Jehovah rebuke you, Satan! Indeed, Jehovah, who has chosen Jerusalem, rebuke you! Is this not a brand plucked from the fire?" Jehovah's word here indicates two things. First, it indicates Jehovah's determination to rebuild Jerusalem, since He has chosen her. Second, it indicates that Jehovah would do something for Joshua, since he was a brand plucked from the fire (Amos 4:11; Jude 1:23a). As the Angel of Jehovah rebuked Satan, He seemed to be saying, "Why have you come here to bother us? I know that you are accusing Joshua and opposing him. I know also that although he is the high priest of My people, he is not that good. He is a brand plucked from the fire, but he is in My hand. Satan, I rebuke you."

In Zechariah 3:1 and 2 we have three parties: Joshua, the Angel of Jehovah, and Satan. In our Christian life, as God's chosen people we are always in this kind of situation. God is in front of us, and the evil one is at our right hand to resist us, to oppose us, to accuse us, and to be our adversary. This is a repetition of the scene in the garden of Eden described in Genesis 2, where God put the man He had created in front of two trees — one denoting God and the other denoting Satan. Zechariah 3 is also a repetition of Genesis 2.

3. The perfection of Christ as the Angel of Jehovah extended to Joshua

Zechariah 3:3-10 shows us how the perfection of Christ as the Angel of Jehovah was extended to Joshua.

a. Removing the filthy garments from him

"Now Joshua was clothed with filthy garments and was standing before the Angel. And He answered and spoke to those standing before Him, saying, Remove the filthy garments from him. Then He said to him, See, I hereby make your iniquity pass from you" (vv. 3-4a). Recently, as I was considering how the high priest could still be clothed with filthy garments, I was reminded how even the believers in the church could steal (Eph. 4:28). We may not steal outwardly, but we may inwardly desire something that belongs to someone else. This is covetousness and greediness. Likewise, every day we speak a lot, and the matters we cover in our talk or gossip may be either dirty or with an evil intention to defame others. This is why we must often pray, "Lord, cleanse me. I realize that I am still filthy because I still live in the flesh, which is altogether filthy."

The Angel of Jehovah knew all the things concerning Joshua and did not give Satan any time to accuse. In such a situation Joshua may not have been at peace. Satan was beside him, the dirty garments were upon him, and the Angel of Jehovah was before him. However, the perfection of Christ as the Angel of Jehovah was extended to Joshua by removing the filthy garments from him, thus making his iniquity pass from him.

b. Clothing him with stately robes

Not only did Joshua's iniquity pass from him, but he was also clothed with "stately robes" (vv. 4b, 5b). A stately robe is a garment that is fitting to one's office and status. For example, judges are clothed with stately robes. Likewise, Joshua was clothed with garments befitting his office and status as high priest.

c. Crowning him with a clean turban upon his head

"And I said, Let them put a clean turban upon his head. And they put the clean turban upon his head and clothed him with garments while the Angel of Jehovah stood by" (v. 5). This clean turban signifies that Joshua had been fully cleansed and was now clean in the presence of Christ as the Angel of Jehovah.

d. Testifying to Him

In verses 6 and 7 Christ as the Angel of Jehovah testified to Joshua. Here testified actually means "charged."

In His charge to Joshua, Christ as the Angel of Jehovah said, "Thus says Jehovah of hosts, If you will walk in My ways and if you will keep My charge, then you will both judge My house and keep My courts, and I will grant you to walk among these standing here." With respect to this charge, I would like to point out that in God's administration among the people of Israel, there were three offices: the priests, the kings, and the prophets. The responsibility of the high priest was to be clear about the matters concerning God's people and to bring these matters to God and wait on God until He enlightened him and gave him a definite answer. The enlightenment and the answer came through the Urim and the Thummim. The high priest, therefore, received God's decision and instruction regarding various situations, and then he passed on the decision and instructions to the king, who was responsible in God's administration to carry them out. We may compare the priest's duty to that of those in the legislative branch of the government, and the king's duty to that of the president in the executive branch. Just as the president is responsible for enforcing the laws passed by the legislature, so the kings in Israel were responsible for carrying out the instructions received from God by the high priest. However, sometimes both the priests and the kings were weak and inadequate. At such times God would raise up the prophets to speak for Him. Here in Zechariah both Joshua the high priest and Zerubbabel the king were rather weak and somewhat discouraged. Therefore, God used Zechariah the prophet to speak for Him and to strengthen and encourage Joshua and Zerubbabel. The vision in chapter three is related to God's decision concerning Joshua. As we will see, the vision in chapter four is related to Zerubbabel and to his responsibility to carry out God's decision to continue and complete the rebuilding of the temple.

e. Strengthening Him with Zerubbabel the Governor of Judah

In verses 8 through 10 Christ as the Angel of Jehovah strengthened Joshua with Zerubbabel the governor of Judah (Hag. 1:1, 14).

1) A type of Christ

Verse 8 says, "Hear then, Joshua the high priest, you and your fellows who sit before you — for they are men of symbol — for, behold, I am bringing forth My Servant, the Shoot." This refers to Zerubbabel who is a type of Christ as the Servant of Jehovah, the Shoot of David, in His humanity and royal faithfulness (Zech. 6:12).

2) The stone that Jehovah set before Joshua

Zechariah 3:9 goes on to say, "For behold, this is the stone that I have set before Joshua: upon one stone are seven eyes. Behold, I will engrave its engraving, declares Jehovah of hosts, and I will remove the iniquity of that land in one day." This stone (Zerubbabel) set before Joshua also typifies Christ (Isa. 28:16; Matt. 21:42). Zerubbabel was a stone set before Joshua to carry out God's economy.

a) Seven eyes being upon this stone

Upon this one stone (Christ) are seven eyes (Zech. 3:9; 4:10). These seven eyes signify the sevenfold intensified Spirit (Rev. 5:6). Christ is the stone with the seven Spirits as His eyes.

b) Jehovah engraving the engraving of the stone

Jehovah will engrave the engraving of the stone (Zech. 3:9b). This indicates that God will work on Christ as the stone for God's redemption, salvation, and building. To engrave is to cut. When Christ was on the cross, He was engraved, cut, by God.

c) Jehovah removing the iniquity of the holy land in one day

Furthermore, Jehovah will remove the iniquity of that land in one day (v. 9c). This indicates that the Christ on whom God has worked will redeem the sin of the land of Israel in one day, the day of His crucifixion (1 Pet. 2:24). Through His death on the cross, Christ the Lamb of God took away the sin of the world (John 1:29).

3) Each of the children of Israel inviting his neighbor to come under the vine and under the fig tree

Zechariah 3:10 concludes, "In that day, declares Jehovah of hosts, each of you will invite his neighbor to come under the vine and under the fig tree." After our sin has been taken away and our situation with God has been appeased, there is peace between us and God, and we can come together to enjoy the vine and the fig tree. This portrays how we enjoy Christ as the vine, the tree of life, and as the fig tree, full of the fruit of life. Christ first came to accomplish redemption, bearing the Spirit and being cut by God on the cross. This then issued in His redemption for our enjoyment of Him as the vine and as the fig tree. The measuring carried out by Christ as the Angel of Jehovah issues in such a wonderful situation.

The Visions of Consolation and Promise

(4)

Scripture Reading: Zech. 4

In this message we will consider the vision of consolation and promise in chapter four of Zechariah.

V. The vision of the golden lampstand and the two olive trees

A. A vision to strengthen Zerubbabel the Governor of Judah in the kingship

The priesthood and the kingship are the two offices in God's administration among His people. These two offices always go together as a pair and are never separated. The priesthood may be compared to the legislative branch of the government, and the kingship, to the executive branch. In God's administration legislative matters are decided by God Himself through the Urim and the Thummim worn by the high priest. The decisions made known through the priesthood are then executed, carried out, by the kingship.

In the church life today, we need both the priesthood and the kingship. Through the exercise of the priesthood, we are brought into God's presence. Through the exercise of the kingship by the older, experienced ones, the church is saved from anarchy and preserved in a good order. For the church life, we as God's people with His administration must have both the priesthood and the kingship.

One function of the priesthood is to teach us how to worship God and how to have the proper remembrance of the Lord at the Lord's table. We should not worship God or remember the Lord according to our natural concept. In John 4:24 the Lord Jesus says, "God is Spirit, and those who worship Him must worship in spirit and truthfulness." This chapter also shows us that the worship God desires is that we drink of Him as the living water. The more we take God as our living water, the more we worship Him. We drink of God not by exercising our mind but by exercising our spirit. Regarding the remembrance of the Lord at the Lord's table, we also need the instruction of the priesthood. It is crucial for us to realize that the way to remember the Lord is not to exercise our mind to recall everything He did in His incarnation, human living, crucifixion, and resurrection; the way to remember Him is to enjoy Him by eating and drinking of Him. As we partake of the bread and of the cup, we remember Him and worship Him.

The visions in Zechariah 3 and 4 are concerned respectively with the priesthood and the kingship. The previous vision in chapter three concerning Joshua is to strengthen Joshua the high priest in the priesthood. To strengthen Joshua is to strengthen the priesthood and establish it. The vision of the golden lampstand and the two olive trees in chapter four is to strengthen Zerubbabel the governor of Judah in the kingship. Zerubbabel was not a king but a governor in the position of a king. Although Zerubbabel was not actually a king, he was nevertheless a descendant, a shoot, of the royal family of David. In chapter three Joshua was measured, and as a result of that measuring, he was strengthened and established through the cleansing. In chapter four Zerubbabel is measured so that through it he may be strengthened and established. The strengthening of Joshua in the priesthood and of Zerubbabel in the kingship are both for the rebuilding of the temple.

B. The significance of the priesthood of Joshua and the lampstand of gold

The priesthood of Joshua signifies the priesthood of the nation of Israel for the nations for God. The lampstand of gold signifies the shining testimony of the nation of Israel toward the nations for God. God had chosen Israel to be a nation of priests (Exo. 19:6). God's intention was to use the nation of Israel as a priesthood to bring the nations to God that they might enter into God's presence to be enlightened, exposed, dealt with, and transfused by God with the divine riches. In addition, the priests were to teach the nations how to worship God and serve God. In order for the priests to do this, they would have to be familiar with God's law and His regulations. In addition to being a nation of priests, Israel was also to be a testimony standing for God. Therefore, in chapter three we have the priesthood, and in chapter four, the lampstand.

C. The lampstand

The angel who spoke with Zechariah roused him and said to him, "What do you see? And I said, I see, and behold, there is a lampstand all of gold with its bowl on top of it and its seven lamps upon it, with seven pipes for each of the lamps on top of it" (Zech. 4:2). The lampstand here signifies the embodiment of the Triune God.

1. Its substance

The substance of the lampstand is gold, signifying the Father as its source and nature.

2. Its form

The form of the lampstand being a lampstand signifies the Son as the embodiment.

3. Its expression

The expression of the lampstand is the seven lamps, signifying the Spirit as the sevenfold intensified expression.

4. Its supply

The supply of the lampstand is the seven pipes for each of the lamps, signifying the sevenfold intensified Spirit of God as its bountiful supply (Phil. 1:19b).

5. Christ, the nation of Israel, and the local churches

First, Christ is the lampstand as the testimony of God (Exo. 25:31-39). Second, the nation of Israel is the lampstand as the testimony of God. Third, the local churches are the lampstands as the testimony of Christ (Rev. 1:12, 20b).

D. The two olive trees on the two sides of the lampstand

Zechariah 4:3 says, "There are two olive trees beside it, one to the right of the bowl and one to the left." These two olive trees signify Joshua the high priest and Zerubbabel the governor at the time, who were the two sons of oil, filled with the Spirit of Jehovah for the rebuilding of God's temple (vv. 3-6, 12-14). The two sons of oil are also the two witnesses in the last three and a half years of the present age, who will be witnesses of God in the great tribulation for the strengthening of God's peoples — the Israelites and the believers in Christ (Rev. 11:3-12; 12:17). These two witnesses are Moses and Elijah. Moses, representing the law, and Elijah, representing the prophets, both testify for God. The expression "the law and the prophets" (Luke 16:16) refers to the Old Testament. The law is centered in Moses, and the prophets are centered in Elijah. These two, Moses and Elijah, will support and supply the persecuted Israelites and the believers during the great tribulation.

The nation of Israel is the lampstand, signifying God's testimony. God's testimony needs the shining. For this shining there must be the burning, and in order for there to be the burning, there must be the supply of olive oil. In order to have the olive oil, there must be some olive trees. The two olive trees on the two sides of the lampstand are the two sons of oil, Joshua and Zerubbabel.

In Zechariah 4:11 the prophet says to the angel, "What are these two olive trees on the right of the lampstand and on its left?" In verse 12 Zechariah goes on to ask, "What are the two olive branches that are by the side of the two golden spouts, which empty the gold from themselves?" In verse 11 there are two trees, and in verse 12, two branches. The two branches are part of the two trees. When the bowl of the lampstand is void of oil, the two trees will supply oil by flowing it out through the branches and into the two spouts. The oil will then flow from the spouts into the bowl, and from the bowl into the lampstand.

The relative pronoun which in verse 12 refers not to the spouts but to the branches. These branches "empty the gold from themselves." To empty the gold is to cause the gold to flow out. The word gold here refers to the oil. The oil and the gold are one. The oil denotes the Spirit, and the Spirit is God. Furthermore, in typology gold signifies God. The gold that fills the bowl is the Spirit; the Spirit is God; and God is typified by gold. As we apply this matter to our experience today, we see that the Spirit who flows out of us is God, and God is gold. Thus, when we minister Christ to others, supplying them with oil, we are actually supplying them with God. God is flowing out from us into them. We all should be olive trees emptying God from ourselves into others. In this way oil will be provided to the needy by those who are olive trees out of which God is flowing.

Let us consider further why the two trees are called two branches. In Zechariah 3 and 4 the same person, Zerubbabel, is signified by a shoot (3:8), a tree (4:3, 11), and a branch (v. 12). This indicates that Zerubbabel himself is not the source. If he were a tree complete in himself, he would be the source. However, he is a tree which is actually a branch of another tree, and that tree is the source. Moreover, Zerubbabel is also a shoot from the other tree. That tree is Christ. Christ is the unique olive tree, and both Zerubbabel and we ourselves are branches, offshoots, of Christ. To branch out is to be an offshoot. Although Christ is the unique olive tree, out from Him many shoots have issued forth. The issuing forth of these shoots is Christ's branching out. These branches, or shoots, are now the many olive trees on earth today. Are you not such an olive tree? As bona fide Christians, we are olive trees. Strictly speaking, we are olive trees not in the sense of being separate trees but in the sense of being branches of Christ, the unique olive tree. As branches we need to supply others with oil, that is, with the Spirit, that they may be enlivened. Praise the Lord that in Christ we are olive trees supplying others with the sevenfold Spirit!

E. Zerubbabel, the Governor of Judah, who laid the foundation of the rebuilding of the temple, bringing forth the topstone

"The angel who spoke with me answered and said to me, Do you not know what these are? And I said, No, sir. And he answered and spoke to me, saying, This is the word of Jehovah to Zerubbabel, saying, Not by might nor by power, but by My Spirit, says Jehovah of hosts. Who are you, O great mountain? Before Zerubbabel you will become a plain, and he will bring forth the topstone with shouts of Grace, grace to it....The hands of Zerubbabel have laid the foundation of this house, and his hands will finish it" (vv. 5-7, 9a). Zerubbabel, the governor of Judah, who laid the foundation of the rebuilding of the temple, will bring forth the topstone, indicating that he will finish the rebuilding of God's temple by the Spirit of Jehovah, not by might nor by power. The prophet Zechariah spoke this word to Zerubbabel in order to support, encourage, strengthen, and establish the hand of Zerubbabel that he might continue the building of the temple unto its consummation.

Whereas chapter three refers to Christ's death for redemption, chapter four speaks of the Spirit for the carrying out of God's economy. According to the New Testament, Christ's death for our redemption is followed by the Spirit. Today we should not only minister Christ to others but also supply them with the Spirit. The Christ we minister is the One who was crucified, who was raised from among the dead, and who in resurrection has become the life-giving Spirit (1 Cor. 15:45b). As we speak to others concerning Christ, we should supply them with the Spirit.

F. The topstone with shouts of grace

The topstone with shouts of "Grace, grace to it!" signifies Christ, who is the grace as the stone, upon which are the seven eyes of Jehovah, the sevenfold intensified Spirit of God for the completion of the rebuilding of God's temple (3:9; 4:7-10; Rev. 5:6). To bring forth the topstone is to complete the building. This topstone is a type of Christ. For God's building Christ is a stone in three aspects. Christ is the foundation stone to uphold God's building (Isa. 28:16; 1 Cor. 3:11), the cornerstone to join together the Gentile and Jewish members of His Body (Eph. 2:20; 1 Pet. 2:6), and the topstone to consummate everything of God's building.

The shouts of "Grace, grace to it!" indicate that the topstone itself is grace. The topstone is grace from God to us, and this grace is Christ. "The Word became flesh and tabernacled among us..full of grace and reality" (John 1:14). This reveals that in His incarnation Christ brought God to us first as grace and then as reality. Grace is God in the Son as our enjoyment; reality is God realized by us in the Son. When God is enjoyed by us, we have grace. When God is realized by us, we have reality. Both grace and reality are Christ. The topstone is therefore the Christ who is the grace from God to us to be the covering of God's building.

Zechariah 4:10 says, "Who has despised the day of small things? For they rejoice when they see the plummet in the hand of Zerubbabel, these seven; they are the eyes of Jehovah running to and fro on the whole earth." "These seven," which are the "eyes of Jehovah," are the seven eyes upon the stone in 3:9. Revelation 5:6 speaks of a Lamb with "seven eyes, which are the seven Spirits of God." The seven eyes of the stone are the seven eyes of Jehovah and also the seven eyes of the Lamb, Christ. It is crucial for us to realize that the stone, Jehovah, and the Lamb are one. Christ the Lamb is the stone, and He is also Jehovah. Thus the seven eyes of the stone and the seven eyes of Jehovah are the seven eyes of Christ. According to Revelation 5:6, these seven eyes are the seven Spirits, that is, the sevenfold intensified Spirit. The seven Spirits are the seven eyes of Christ. This means that the Holy Spirit is the eyes of Christ. This indicates that Christ and the Holy Spirit, although distinct, are not separate. Just as our eyes are essentially one with our body, so the Holy Spirit is essentially one with Christ.

Christ is the stone engraved by God the Father (Zech. 3:9). The engraved One is Christ, and the engraving One is the Father. Although the Father and the Son are distinct, they are essentially one in the accomplishment of eternal redemption. As the result of this redemption, we may now enjoy Christ as the Spirit, even as the sevenfold intensified Spirit. According to Paul's word in 2 Corinthians 13:14, we have the love of God the Father as the source, the grace of Christ as the course, and the fellowship of the Holy Spirit as the transmission for our enjoyment. From all this we see that redemption has been accomplished by the Son, and now the Spirit is supplied to us for God's building. By the Spirit the building of the church will be consummated.

The Visions of Consolation and Promise

(5)

Scripture Reading: Zech. 5

In the first five visions which Zechariah saw (1:7—4:14), God spoke a comforting, consoling, and encouraging word to Joshua, Zerubbabel, and the people. God said that He would be with them and do something through them. In this way He encouraged them not to stop the building work on the temple, but rather to continue to finish the building of the temple under the priesthood of Joshua, the high priest, and under the kingship of Zerubbabel, the governor. Whereas the first five visions were positive, the last three visions Zechariah saw (5:1—6:8) were negative, because they concern God's universal judgment on the evil people and the evil on earth. These three visions are the vision of the flying scroll (5:1-4), the vision of the ephah vessel (vv. 5-11), and the vision of the four chariots (6:1-8). In this message we will consider the two visions recorded in chapter five.

VI. The vision of the flying scroll

A. The significance of the flying scroll

"Then I lifted up my eyes again and I saw, and behold, there was a flying scroll. And he said to me, What do you see? And I said, I see a flying scroll" (5:1-2a). The flying scroll signifies God's righteous law and its justice (just judgment). Without judgment, there may be righteousness, but there will not be justice. When a particular case is subject to righteous judgment, then there will be justice.

B. Its length of twenty cubits and its breadth of ten cubits

The length of the flying scroll is twenty cubits and the breadth is ten cubits, signifying the testimony of the law by two squares of ten cubits by ten cubits. The number two is the number for testimony, and the number ten signifies completion in fullness. Therefore, the law of God is a testimony to the whole world, and the two squares of ten cubits by ten cubits is the completion in fullness of the law.

C. The curse

Verse 3a says, "Then he said to me, This is the curse that goes forth over the face of all the land." The curse signifies God's punishment in judging sins according to His righteous law. God's law is righteous, and this righteous law does not tolerate unrighteousness. The fact that God's judgment is a curse indicates that it is a very serious matter. This scroll will be the base of God's thorough judgment over all the sin on earth.

D. The significance of stealing

Verses 3b and 4b speak of those who steal. Stealing signifies sins toward man, which are the issue of covetousness. Stealing issues from greed and covetousness. Today is an age of stealing. Business and trade involve stealing. Everyone is greedy and full of covetousness. The apostle Paul could keep many of the Ten Commandments, but he could not fulfill the commandment concerning coveting (Rom. 7:7-8).

E. The significance of swearing falsely by Jehovah's name

Zechariah 5 also speaks concerning those who swear falsely by Jehovah's name (vv. 3c, 4c). Swearing falsely by Jehovah's name signifies sins toward God, which are the issue of a wrong relationship with God. Those who swear falsely in this way are not honest, faithful, and sincere with God. They may claim to speak and act in the name of God, but their claim is a falsehood. Such falsehood is surely an offense to God.

The law of God given to Moses is of two sections. One section concerns the relationship between man and God, and the other concerns the relationships among men. God requires that we be right with Him and also right with other people. To be right in this way is to be righteous. Those who are not right with both God and man will suffer God's judgment.

F. God's judgment of sins reaching the house of the sinners and lodging there

Speaking of God's judgment, verse 4 says, "I will cause it to go forth, declares Jehovah of hosts; and it will enter the house of him who steals and the house of him who swears falsely by My name; and it will lodge overnight within his house and consume it, both with its timbers and its stones." From this we see that the exercise of God's judgment of sins will be most serious and also very thorough.

VII. The vision of the ephah vessel

Verses 5 through 11 describe the vision of the ephah vessel, which is the measuring vessel, a container able to hold one ephah, used for purchasing and selling in business.

A. Its appearance in all the land

"Then the angel who spoke with me went forth and said to me, Lift up now your eyes and see what this is that goes forth. And I said, What is it? And he said, This is the ephah vessel that goes forth; and he said, This is their appearance in all the land" (vv. 5-6). A large percentage of the world's population is engaged in business or commerce. The appearance of business is not that bad; rather, in all the land commerce seems to have a proper appearance. But as we will see, actually today's commerce is totally wicked.

B. A woman sitting within the ephah vessel

"This is a woman sitting within the ephah vessel. Then he said, This is Wickedness" (vv. 7b-8a). This reveals that the woman sitting within the ephah vessel signifies the wickedness contained in commerce, such as covetousness, deceit, and the love of mammon. The seller loves money and tries to get money out of the buyer's pocket; the buyer also loves money and tries to obtain the things he wants at a low price, thereby saving money.

The vision in Zechariah 5 corresponds to that of Babylon the Great in Revelation 18. These visions show us that in the sight of God the wickedness contained in commerce is a kind of idolatry and fornication. Business is an adulterous woman desirous of making money.

C. A lead cover thrown over the opening of the ephah vessel

In Zechariah 5:7 and 8 we see that a lead cover, a lead weight, is thrown over the opening of the ephah vessel. This signifies the restriction of the wickedness in commerce by God's sovereignty. Wickedness is hidden and concealed in international trade. If commerce, especially international trade, could be restricted, the whole earth would be holy.

D. Two women going forth

"Then I lifted up my eyes and I saw, and behold, there were two women going forth" (v. 9a). The one woman becoming two women signifies the double effect of commerce once it becomes free of the restriction.

E. Two women lifting up the ephah vessel between the earth and the heavens

The two women had wings like the wings of a stork, and the wind was in their wings. They lifted up the ephah vessel between the earth and the heavens (v. 9b). All this signifies the rapid spreading of the wicked commerce.

F. A house built for the woman in the land of Shinar

"I said to the angel who spoke with me, Where are they taking the ephah vessel? And he said to me, To build a house for her in the land of Shinar; and when it is prepared, she will be set there in her own place" (vv. 10-11). This signifies that God's sovereignty will cause the wickedness in business, which the people of Israel learned of the Babylonians in their captivity, to go back to Babylon (the land of Shinar). Let this wickedness return to Babylon. All the people among God's elect should be honest and simple in their living.

The Visions of Consolation and Promise

(6)

Scripture Reading: Zech. 6

The visions in Zechariah 5 and 6 are all concerning God's judgment. In chapter five the vision of the flying scroll (vv. 1-4) reveals that God's righteous law and its justice cannot allow any unrighteousness on earth. We must be right with both God and man; otherwise, we will suffer God's judgment. The vision of the ephah vessel (vv. 5-11) shows us that the most evil thing on earth is commerce. Apparently commerce is something good, but actually it is evil, full of wickedness. In this message we will go on to consider the two matters revealed in chapter six: the vision of the four chariots (vv. 1-8) and the concluding word to confirm the eight visions in this book (vv. 9-15).

VIII. The vision of the four chariots

In 6:1-8 we have the last of the eight visions in the book of Zechariah — the vision of the four chariots.

A. The significance of the four chariots

"Then I lifted up my eyes again and I saw, and behold, there were four chariots coming forth from between the two mountains" (6:1a). These four chariots signify the four winds (vv. 4-8) from the four corners of the earth (Rev. 7:1-3) for God's judgment of sins upon the earth. These four winds are used by God to carry out His administration in the entire universe. In particular, they are used by God to carry out His judgment, not mainly on people but on nations, governments, and kingdoms.

In the vision in Zechariah 1:18-21, Zechariah saw four horns which were raised up to damage and destroy God's people Israel. Then God prepared four "craftsmen" to destroy these four horns. The first of these craftsmen was the Persian Empire, sovereignly used by God to destroy Babylon, the first horn. Persia was a great empire; its territory stretched from the Mediterranean Sea to the Indian Ocean. Surely it was not easy for anyone to conquer that vast empire. But Alexander the Great, a young man, came and swiftly defeated all of the Persian Empire. This was all under God's sovereign blowing of the wind to produce the second craftsman in order to destroy the second horn. Then Julius Caesar came with the Roman army and in a short time conquered the Grecian Empire, founded by Alexander. The Roman Empire, the last horn, has now lasted for over two thousand years.

1. Each chariot being equipped with horses

"With the first chariot were red horses, and with the second chariot were black horses, and with the third chariot were white horses, and with the fourth chariot were strong, speckled horses" (6:2-3). That each chariot was equipped with horses signifies the quick movement of God's judgment. From our point of view, God's judgment may be slow in coming. However, according to God's view, His judgment comes swiftly with a quick movement.

2. Horses of different colors

These horses of different colors, red, black, white, and speckled, signify the different manners of God's judgment.

When the Lord Jesus comes, He will be swifter than the wind; He will be like lightning. The last wind will bring in Christ as the last, the consummating, Craftsman, who will destroy Antichrist with his kingdom and tread the great winepress. In an instant He will crush the great human image (Dan. 2) from the toes to the head, terminating the entire human government on this earth.

B. The significance of the two mountains

Zechariah 6:1 speaks of two mountains. These two mountains signify a testimony of God's judgments on the earth. From between the two mountains, the four winds come forth to testify to the whole earth that God is on the throne and that the earth is under His administration.

C. The significance of the mountains of brass

"The mountains were mountains of brass" (v. 1b). In typology brass signifies judgment. Thus, these two mountains of brass signify mountains of judgment. God's judgment comes to carry out His testimony.

D. These who are going forth to the land of the north giving rest to God's Spirit in the land of the north

"Then He called out to me and spoke to me, saying, See, these who are going forth to the land of the north have given My Spirit rest in the land of the north" (v. 8). This signifies that the judgments on the countries of the north, Assyria and Babylon (Jer. 1:14-15; 4:6; 6:1; 25:9; 46:10; Ezek. 1:4), have given rest to God's Spirit. The judgment on these countries was a comfort to God.

IX. The concluding word to confirm the eight visions

God gave eight visions to comfort Israel. Zechariah 6:9-15 is the concluding word to confirm the eight visions of comfort, consolation, and encouragement.

A. By the crowning of Joshua the high priest

The visions are confirmed by the crowning of Joshua the high priest — typifying Christ in His priesthood — linked with Zerubbabel the governor of Judah, typifying Christ as the Shoot of David in His kingship, to hold the two offices, the priesthood and the kingship, in peace on His throne (vv. 9-13). Prior to the time of Zechariah, no one had held both offices, for the priesthood is of the tribe of Levi and of the family of Aaron, and the kingship is of the tribe of Judah and of the family of David. King Uzziah, however, tried to usurp the office of the priesthood (2 Chron. 26:18-21), but God punished him with leprosy, and he was a leper until the day of his death.

In Zechariah 6:9-13 both Joshua and Zerubbabel are a type of Christ. This means that two persons typify one person. Christ is the unique One to hold the two offices, the priesthood and the kingship. When He comes, He will put the priesthood and the kingship together on His shoulders. In all of history He is the only person who is qualified to bear the responsibilities of these two offices in God's administration. Thus, in Hebrews 7 Christ is both the High Priest and the King, as typified by Melchizedek. In Genesis 14 Melchizedek was first a king, and then he came as a priest to Abraham, ministering the bread and the wine. This indicates that he was both a king and a priest. Because Melchizedek bore both offices, he was a type of Christ as the One who would bear both the priesthood and the kingship in God's administration.

B. For the assurance of the completion of the rebuilding of the temple of God

"He will shoot forth from His place and will build the temple of Jehovah. Indeed, it is He who will build the temple of Jehovah" (Zech. 6:12b-13a). This indicates that the concluding word in chapter six is for the assurance of the completion of the rebuilding of the temple of God (v. 15). The crowning of Joshua was an assurance to the people that God would do something to accomplish the rebuilding of the temple.

C. The splendid crown being as a reminder in the temple of Jehovah

"The splendid crown will be as a reminder in the temple of Jehovah" (v. 14). This signifies the remembrance of the coming Messiah (Christ) by God's chosen people. The crown with which Joshua was crowned was removed from his head and put in the temple. It was to be a reminder to the children of Israel to remember the coming Messiah, the One who would come to be the King and the Priest to execute God's administration for the fulfillment of God's economy.

The Advice to Israel to Turn from the Vanity of Their Ritualistic Religion to the Reality of a Godly Life and the Desire of Jehovah to Restore Israel

Scripture Reading: Zech. 7; Zech. 8

In this message we will consider Zechariah 7 and 8. These chapters cover the advice to Israel to turn from the vanity of their ritualistic religion (7:3-6; 8:19a) to the reality of a godly life (7:7-14; 8:16-17, 19b) and also the desire of Jehovah to restore Israel (8:2-23).

I. The advice to Israel to turn from the vanity of their ritualistic religion to the reality of a godly life

A. To turn from the vanity of their ritualistic religion

Zechariah 7:3-6 speaks of the vanity of ritualistic religion. In particular, these verses mention weeping and fasting. The people of Israel wept, fasted, and separated themselves in the tenth month to express their grieving for the attacking and besieging of Jerusalem by the Babylonians (Jer. 52:4). The people wept, fasted, and separated themselves in the fourth month to express their grieving for the breaking down of the city of Jerusalem (2 Kings 25:3-4). Israel wept, fasted, and separated themselves in the fifth month to express their grieving for the burning of the temple of God and the city of Jerusalem (Jer. 52:12-13). God's people also wept, fasted, and separated themselves in the seventh month to express their grieving for the murder of Gedaliah (2 Kings 25:22-26).

B. To turn to the reality of a godly life

Israel was advised not only to turn from the vanity of their ritualistic religion but also to turn to the reality of a godly life.

1. To hearken to the word of God

First, Israel was told to hearken to the word of God proclaimed by the prophets (Zech. 7:7, 11).

2. Judging with judgment of truth

If the people of Israel were to have the reality of a godly life, they would have to judge with judgment of truth, show lovingkindness and compassion each to his brother, not oppress the widow and the orphan, the stranger and the poor, and none of them was to think evil in his heart about his brother (vv. 9-10; 8:16b-17a).

3. Each man speaking truth to his neighbor

Further, God's people were charged each man to speak truth to his neighbor. They were not to think evil in their hearts about their neighbor, and they were not to love a false oath, for these are things hated by Jehovah (8:16a, 17b).

4. Loving truth and peace

Finally, the children of Israel were to love truth and peace (v. 19b). They were advised to turn from their ritualistic religion with its weeping and fasting to the reality of a godly life, a life full of righteousness, lovingkindness, compassion, truth, and peace.

II. The desire of Jehovah to restore Israel

Zechariah 8 reveals the desire of Jehovah to restore Israel. This is a precious matter.

A. The desire of Jehovah and the restoration of Israel

1. Jehovah of hosts being jealous for Zion with a Great Jealousy

Jehovah of hosts is jealous for Zion with a great jealousy. Indeed, He is jealous for her with great wrath to her enemies (v. 2). Although God is love, He nevertheless has great wrath toward the enemies of His people. He is jealous for His beloved elect.

2. Jehovah returning to Zion and dwelling within Jerusalem

Jehovah returns to Zion, and He will dwell within Jerusalem. Jerusalem will be called the City of Truth, and the mountain of Jehovah of hosts, the Holy Mountain (v. 3).

3. Old men and old women dwelling in the streets of Jerusalem

Old men and old women will dwell in the streets of Jerusalem, each with his staff in his hand due to the multitude of his days (v. 4). This indicates that the city will be in a marvelous situation and that the old men and old women will have the real enjoyment of life.

4. The streets of the city being full of boys and girls playing

The streets of the city will be full of boys and girls playing (v. 5). This indicates that the city will be peaceful and very pleasant.

5. It being wonderful both in the sight of the remnant of Israel and in the sight of Jehovah

The situation of Jerusalem in the restoration will be so pleasant that it will be wonderful both in the sight of the remnant of Israel and in the sight of Jehovah (v. 6). When the people see the pleasantness of Jerusalem, they may say, "This is wonderful!" and God may say, "Yes, this is wonderful!"

6. Jehovah saving His people from the land of the east and from the land of the going down of the sun

Jehovah is about to save His people from the land of the east and from the land of the going down of the sun and bring them to Jerusalem, and they will dwell in it. They will be Jehovah's people, and Jehovah will be their God in truth and in righteousness (vv. 7-8). I believe that the land of the east is Babylon and that the land of the going down of the sun is Spain, for at that time Spain was considered the uttermost part of the earth, the place of sunset.

7. The children of Israel being encouraged to be strong

The children of Israel should be strong, those who heard the words from the prophets given in the day when the foundation of the temple was laid so that it might be rebuilt (v. 9). This is a word encouraging the children of Israel to be strong and bold and to finish the work of rebuilding God's house.

8. The remnant of the children of Israel earning wages, and their animals too

The remnant of the children of Israel will earn wages, and their animals will too. There will be peace for them to go out or come in. Jehovah will not be to them as He was in the former days (vv. 10-11).

9. Jehovah causing the remnant of Israel to inherit blessings

The vine will give forth its fruit; the land will give forth its produce; and the heavens will give their dew, that is, their rain. Jehovah will cause the remnant of Israel to inherit all these blessings (v. 12). Because of these blessings, the entire country will be fruitful and productive for the enjoyment of the people.

10. Jehovah saving the people, and the people becoming a blessing

Just as they were a curse among the nations, so Jehovah will save them, and they will be a blessing. They should not fear, but their hands should be strong. Just as He intended to do harm to them when their fathers provoked Him to anger, and He did not repent, so again He intends in these days to do good to Jerusalem and to the house of Judah (vv. 13-15). God will be good to them in every way.

11. The fasts becoming joy and rejoicing and cheerful feasts to the house of Judah

Finally, the fasts of the fourth month and the fifth month, and the fasts of the seventh month and the tenth month, will become joy and rejoicing and cheerful feasts to the house of Judah (v. 19). Instead of fasts there will be feasts full of good food for the enjoyment of the people of Israel.

B. The nations coming to Israel to entreat the favor of Jehovah, and the children of Israel being priests to them

The nations will come to Israel to entreat the favor, the grace, of Jehovah, and the children of Israel will be priests to them (vv. 20-23). By this time the entire nation of Israel will be a priesthood. They will teach the Gentiles, the nations, to know God's way and God's person, and they will teach them to worship and serve God. As priests, they will bring the nations into the presence of God that they may be enlightened, corrected, and favored with all the riches of God. This is the priesthood. In the one thousand years of the kingdom, after the Jews are saved at the Lord's coming back, they will become the priests to teach all the repentant nations.

1. Peoples, even the inhabitants of many cities, coming to Israel

Not just one kind of people but peoples, even the inhabitants of many cities from different countries, will come to Israel and say, "Let us go at once to entreat the favor [grace] of Jehovah and to seek Jehovah of hosts; and the other: I will go, too" (v. 21). Verse 22 goes on to say, "Indeed, many peoples and strong nations will come to seek Jehovah of hosts in Jerusalem and to entreat the favor of Jehovah." I hope that one day in all the local churches the situation will be like this. Whenever someone would say, "Let us go to the meeting," another would say, "I will go, too." This will be the situation in the millennium. Not only all the people of Israel but also the Gentiles who are living with them will seek God.

2. Ten men taking hold of the skirt of a Jewish man and saying that they will go with Him

In those days, from all the languages of the nations, ten men will take hold of the skirt of a Jewish man, saying, "Let us go with you, for we have heard that God is with you" (v. 23; Isa. 2:2-3a). In some way God will reverse the situation of Babel and deal with the problem caused by the different languages among the nations. God did this once already, at Pentecost (Acts 2). What happened at Pentecost is a prefigure of what will take place during the age of the millennial kingdom.

3. The children of Israel being priests to the nations

The children of Israel will be priests to the nations (Isa. 2:3b-4a). God's intention according to Exodus 19:6 was to have Israel as a nation of priests, and He has never forgotten this. God has been waiting for an opportune time to do this, but there has not yet been the chance for God to do it. In the time of the restoration, all the Israelites will be priests. They will be very busy as priests to the nations, teaching them how to worship and serve Jehovah. The nations were formerly idol worshippers or atheists, but they all will turn to God, and God will turn to them to be their God. Therefore, they will need to learn how to worship and serve Jehovah.

This was the encouraging word spoken to the children of Israel. Zechariah seemed to be saying, "Forget about fasting and weeping. Turn to God and turn to a godly life. Then a time of restoration will come among you, and the nations will turn to you and will come to dwell with you as God's people. You will take the lead to help them, to teach them, to usher them into the worship of God."

During the millennial kingdom, Israel will be in the earthly part, whereas we, the New Testament believers, will be in the heavenly part. We will be the kings, the co-kings with Christ, and we will also be the priests, the heavenly priests, to serve God. However, not all of the believers will be there but only the overcoming believers. Whether or not the millennium will be a time of testing for us will depend on whether or not we have been overcomers in our Christian life in this age. If we are the overcomers, we will be in the heavenly part of the millennial kingdom as kings and priests. If not, we will be in some other place to be disciplined and to become matured.

The Prophecies of Encouragement

(1)

Scripture Reading: Zech. 9

Zechariah's burden was to help the returned people of Israel to see God's purpose. At that time God's purpose was to recover the temple as the center of His interest. Through Zechariah the Lord seemed to be saying to them, "I do not want your fasting and weeping. Forget about these things. I would even ask you to forget what I did in the past to deal with you. You need to know what I want you to do today. I want you to realize that My desire is that the temple would be built up by My people to be the center and reality of My interest on earth." Today God's intention, His desire, is that we would be one with Him. He has brought us back to the very site, to the ground, even to the foundation of the temple. God wants us to see that His interest, desire, and burden are to finish the building of this temple.

God has a burden. This burden is that He may gain a people in this age to know His heart, to realize His desire, and to be one with Him to build up the Body of Christ. This is what God wants. God's desire is related to His economy. God's economy is to have Christ as everything, to have Him as the center and the circumference, the centrality and the universality, of God's move on this earth. We all need to see this.

Throughout the book of Zechariah Christ is revealed. In chapter one we see Christ as the Man riding on a red horse to take care of God's suffering people; in chapter two, as the One who is measuring Jerusalem; in chapter three, as the One, the High Priest, typified by Joshua the high priest and signified by the stone with seven eyes; in chapter four, as the One, the real King, typified by Zerubbabel; and in chapter six, as the unique One who is qualified to bear the office of both the priesthood and the kingship for the consummation of the building up of God's temple. Now we must go on to see that this all-inclusive Christ is altogether wrapped up with human history. Human history from Adam to the last person of the human race is nothing without Christ. However, according to God's economy, Christ is intimately involved with human history. This means that Christ is wrapped up with every crucial aspect of the four empires signified by the great human image in Daniel 2. As we will see, the Christ revealed in Zechariah 9—14 is a Christ who is involved with human history in a fine, particular, and even intimate way.

The visions in chapters one through six of Zechariah were mainly for consolation to the children of Israel, whereas the prophecies in chapters nine through fourteen are mainly for their encouragement. Without Christ there is neither consolation nor encouragement. The consolation in Zechariah 1—6 is Christ, and the encouragement in Zechariah 9—14 is also Christ. In this message we will consider the first of the prophecies of encouragement.

I. The prophecy concerning the nations around Judah in relation to Israel

The prophecy in Zechariah 9 concerns the nations around Judah in relation to Israel.

A. Concerning the destruction carried out on the nations around Judah by Alexander the Great

The prophecy in verses 1 through 7 concerns the destruction carried out on the nations around Judah by Alexander the Great, king of the Grecian Empire (336-323 B.C., with the influence of his four successors up to 44 B.C.), prophesied by Daniel in his book as the abdomen and the thighs of the great human image in 2:32c, as the third beast in 7:6, as the male goat in 8:5, and as a mighty king in 11:3.

B. The Lord protecting Jerusalem with its temple as His house

Zechariah 9:8 says, "I will encamp around My house because of an army, / Because of him who passes by and returns; / And no oppressor will pass over them any more; / For now I see with My eyes." This reveals that during the attack of Alexander the Great, the Lord protected Jerusalem with its temple as His house. Although Alexander, a mighty king, caused damage to so many nations around Judah, he did not cause much damage to Judah and Jerusalem, and he did not damage the temple at all.

C. Christ being temporarily welcomed as the King into Jerusalem in a lowly form

The two verses in chapter nine that are concerned with Christ, verses 9 and 10, are an insertion. This means that verse 11 is actually the continuation of verse 8. Verse 9 says, "Exult greatly, O daughter of Zion; / Shout, O daughter of Jerusalem! / Now your King comes to you. / He is righteous and bears salvation; / Lowly and riding upon a donkey, / Even upon a colt, the foal of a donkey." This reveals that Christ would come in a righteous way with salvation for us and that He would ride upon a donkey, even a colt of a donkey. This verse was fulfilled in the four Gospels when Jesus Christ came into Jerusalem the last time. He came as a King, but as a lowly King, a humiliated King, riding not on a majestic horse but on a colt.

D. The millennial kingdom as a time of restoration

Verse 10 says, "I will cut off the chariot from Ephraim / And the horse from Jerusalem, / And the battle bow will be cut off; / And He will speak peace unto the nations, / And His dominion will be from sea to sea / And from the River unto the ends of the earth." This refers to the millennial kingdom, which will be a time of restoration. In the millennial kingdom God will stop all the fighting. This word concerning the kingdom surely must have been a comfort and an encouragement to the people of Israel.

The sequence in this chapter is very meaningful. Verses 1 through 7 speak concerning the damage and devastation Alexander the Great caused to the nations surrounding Judah. Then verse 8 continues to say that the Lord Himself encamped around His temple within the holy city. This saved Judah with Jerusalem and the temple from the devastation of Alexander. Jerusalem and the temple were spared and saved from the devastation of the enemy. That was a good deliverance and a sign of the coming restoration. However, the coming restoration needs the coming of Christ. For this reason, after the word in verse 8 concerning the deliverance of Jerusalem and the temple, verse 9 says that Christ is coming, being righteous and bearing salvation. Eventually, the situation was right and fitting for Christ's coming, and He came in humility, and also in an intimate manner, riding upon a donkey.

What should be the issue of Christ's coming? As verse 10 indicates, after His coming peace and restoration should be here, and God's dominion should also be here. In the restoration the first item is peace: "He will speak peace unto the nations." The second item is dominion: "His dominion will be from sea to sea."

However, when Christ came the first time, He was only welcomed a little and was ultimately rejected, detested to the uttermost, and put to death by being crucified. Regarding His rejection by the children of Israel, the Lord Jesus said, "Jerusalem, Jerusalem, who kills the prophets and stones those who are sent to her! How often I desired to gather your children together, the way a hen gathers her brood under her wings, and you would not! Behold, your house is left to you desolate" (Matt. 23:37-38). The word house denotes the house of God, which was the temple. It was the house of God, but here it is called "your house." The house of God had become their house, and it would be utterly destroyed by Titus in A.D. 70 (Matt. 24:2).

Because the children of Israel rejected Christ the King, the restoration was somewhat suspended, and a time of judgment over the children of Israel entered in, which has lasted about twenty centuries. Therefore, Christ needs to come a second time, this time not riding a donkey but coming as lightning (Matt. 24:27). Then peace and the eternal kingdom, as God's dominion, will be on the earth from sea to sea. This is the sequence according to the spiritual significance.

E. Concerning the victory of the Jewish Maccabean heroes over Antiochus Epiphanes

The prophecy in verses 11 through 17 of Zechariah 9 concerns the victory of the Jewish Maccabean heroes over Antiochus Epiphanes, the king of Syria (175-163 B.C.), the kingdom of the north, prophesied by Daniel in his book in 8:9-14, 23-25 and 11:28-35. Antiochus Epiphanes was the first type of the coming Antichrist, who will do the evil things prophesied in Daniel 8:10-13, 23-25; 11:30-32a.

God raised up the Maccabean heroes to encounter Antiochus and to defeat him. Daniel 11:32b says, "The people who know their God will show strength and take action." I believe that Maccabeus and his followers knew that this word applied to themselves and that they were encouraged by it. They showed strength and took action against Antiochus Epiphanes.

Zechariah 9:13 says, "I will bend Judah for Myself, / And I will fill a bow with Ephraim; / And I will stir up your sons, O Zion, / Against your sons, O Javan; / And I will make you like a warrior's sword." The word Javan here refers to Greece and is the key to understanding verses 11 through 17. The sons of Greece are Antiochus and those with him, and the sons of Zion are the Maccabeans. Thus, verse 13 is saying that at the time of Antiochus Epiphanes God would stir up His sons, the sons of Zion, against the sons of Greece.

Verses 14 and 15 go on to say, "And Jehovah will appear above them, / And His arrow will go forth like lightning; / And the Lord Jehovah will blow the trumpet, / And He will go in the whirlwinds of the south. / Jehovah of hosts will defend them; / And they will devour and trample the sling stones. / And they will drink; they will be noisy as if with wine; / And they will be filled like a sacrificial basin, / Like the corners of the altar." In these verses them and they refer to the Maccabeans, who were to be defended by God.

Verse 16 continues, "Jehovah their God will save them in that day as the flock of His people, / For they will be like the stones of a crown, sparkling in His land." "That day" refers to December 25, 161 B.C.

Verse 17 concludes, "For how great is their goodness, and how great their beauty! / Grain will make the young men flourish, / And new wine, the virgins." This is a word spoken in congratulations to the Maccabeans for their victory.

The first part of this chapter is concerned with Alexander the Great, and the last part, with Antiochus Epiphanes. A word concerning Christ, who is wrapped up with human history, is inserted in verses 9 and 10. Christ, of course, did not come during the time of the Grecian Empire but during the time of the Roman Empire. As we will see in a later message, Zechariah also prophesied concerning the Roman Empire.

The Prophecies of Encouragement

(2)

Scripture Reading: Zech. 10

In this message we will consider the prophecy of encouragement in Zechariah 10.

II. The prophecy concerning the Lord's loving visitation to Israel

The prophecy in chapter ten of Zechariah concerns the Lord's loving visitation to Israel.

As we will see, this loving visitation is actually Christ's coming to Israel.

A. The Lord encouraging the children of Israel to seek more blessings

"Ask rain of Jehovah / At the time of spring rain, / Of Jehovah who makes the lightning, / And He will give them showers of rain, / To everyone herbage in the field" (v. 1). The word rain here signifies blessing. To ask for more rain is to seek more blessing. Thus, in this verse the Lord is encouraging the children of Israel to seek more blessings while He would be favorable to them. While the Lord is so favorable to us, we should ask Him to send us even more favor. Since God is giving us showers of rain, we should ask Him for more rain. This indicates that we all need to pray for the Lord's abundant blessing.

B. The Lord punishing the false shepherds

Verses 2 and 3a say, "The teraphim have spoken vanity, / And the diviners have seen a lie / And have spoken false dreams; they comforted in vain. / Therefore the people have wandered like sheep; / They are afflicted because there is no shepherd. / My anger is kindled against the shepherds, / And I will punish the male goats." Among the Jews in the ancient time, many possessed teraphim, which were images or false gods kept in their homes. All those false gods and all the diviners spoke vanity and false dreams; they comforted in vain. Therefore, the people wandered like sheep. They were afflicted because there was no shepherd. Verse 3 tells us that the Lord's anger was kindled against the shepherds and that He would punish the male goats. The shepherds here are the male goats. The proper shepherds are the prophets, the proper ones who speak for God.

Today we have a wonderful practice in the church life. We encourage every saint to prophesy; we make every saint a prophet. In the Lord's move among His people today, the most important thing is to speak for Him. Paul encouraged all the saints to prophesy (1 Cor. 14:1, 24, 31, 39a).

C. The Lord visiting the house of Judah as His flock

"Jehovah of hosts has visited His flock, the house of Judah, / And will make them like His horse of majesty in battle" (Zech. 10:3b). God came to His people in such a gracious way to visit them. His visiting them was Christ's coming to them. He came in the man, Jesus. Of course, chapter ten does not mention the name Jesus Christ or Messiah, but the word visited here should be understood as Christ's coming. Two thousand years ago He came in the form of a man.

This portion of the Word speaks about the Shepherd of God's flock. In the New Testament the Lord Jesus likened Himself to a shepherd. He came as the real Shepherd and blamed the other shepherds, who were the elders, the scribes, and the priests. They were the wrong shepherds, but the Lord Jesus was the unique Shepherd. He even told us that He was the good Shepherd who gave up His life for the sheep (John 10:11, 14-15). On the one hand, the Lord punished the false shepherds; on the other hand, He, the real Shepherd, has visited His flock.

By visiting His flock He makes them like a horse of majesty. Are you a sheep or a horse of majesty? We all need to progress so that we are no longer sheep but horses of majesty. After being touched by the Shepherd, every weak sheep will become a horse of majesty.

D. From Judah coming forth the cornerstone, the peg, the battle bow, and every ruler together

Zechariah 10:4 continues, "From him will come forth the cornerstone, from him the peg, / From him the battle bow, / From him every ruler together." The pronoun him used three times in this verse refers to Judah in the previous verse. Verse 4 indicates that when we become horses of majesty, we become a source of cornerstones, pegs, battle bows, and rulers. When we become horses, we produce these four kinds of things.

E. The house of Judah and the people of Ephraim being as mighty men trampling their enemies

The house of Judah and the people of Ephraim will be as mighty men trampling their enemies, for Jehovah is with them (v. 5). Jehovah will strengthen the house of Judah and will save the house of Joseph. Jehovah will bring them back, for He has had compassion on them, and it will be as though Jehovah had not rejected them. Jehovah is their God, and He will answer them (v. 6). Their hearts will rejoice as if with wine, and their hearts will exult in Jehovah (v. 7). This should be our situation and condition in the church life today.

F. Jehovah whistling for them and gathering them

Verses 8 through 12 reveal further aspects of the Lord's loving visitation to Israel. Verse 8 says, "I will whistle for them and gather them, for I have redeemed them; / And they will multiply as they have multiplied." The Lord's whistling is not shrill but mild and gentle, somewhat like the singing of a bird. Often during our time of morning revival, the Lord whistles to us, calling us and gathering us to Him.

Verses 9 and 10 continue, "I will sow them among the peoples; and in distant lands they will remember Me; / And they will live with their children and return. / I will also bring them back from the land of Egypt / And gather them out of Assyria; / And to the land of Gilead and Lebanon I will bring them; / And there will not be enough room found for them." The Lord's people will surely multiply. I believe that we will see many new ones in the local churches. That will be the real multiplication in the new way.

Verse 11 goes on to say, "He will pass through the sea of distress / And strike the waves in the sea, / And all the depths of the Nile will dry up; / And the pride of Assyria will be brought down." The sea mentioned here is the Red Sea which, along with the Nile, protects Egypt and keeps it separate. However, God will strike the waves in the Red Sea and dry up the Nile.

Verse 12 concludes, "I will strengthen them in Jehovah, / And they will walk about in His name, / Declares Jehovah." The I here is Jehovah, indicating that Jehovah will strengthen His people in Himself. They will then walk about in His name. To be in someone's name is to be one with the person who is the reality of that name. To be in God's name is to be one with God in our daily walk, living, walking, and having our being in God's name.

All of chapter ten talks about God's loving visitation. We need to realize and remember that this visitation is actually Christ's coming. I can testify from my experience that when we enjoy the Lord's loving visitation, our situation is exactly like that of God's people described in this chapter. Often after we enjoy such a loving visitation, our situation changes. In His visitation He encourages us to seek more blessings. We are little lambs, but after His loving visitation, we become horses. We are not that bold or strong, but after the Lord's visitation with His dear touch, we are strengthened to become horses of majesty in battle. Eventually, the Lord strengthens us in Himself so that we may walk about in His name.

The Prophecies of Encouragement

(3)

Scripture Reading: Zech. 11

In this message we will consider the prophecy in chapter eleven of Zechariah.

III. The prophecy concerning the living of Israel under the oppression of the Roman Empire

The prophecy in Zechariah 11 covers the living of Israel under the oppression of the Roman Empire. As we will see, in this chapter there is evidence which proves that it is concerned with the tyranny of the Roman Empire.

A. The destruction carried out in the neighborhood of Israel by the Roman Empire

Verses 1 through 3 reveal the destruction carried out in the neighborhood of Israel by the Roman Empire. The fire in verse 1 refers to the coming of the Roman Caesar to devastate Lebanon and Jordan.

B. The children of Israel falling into their neighbors' hand and into the hand of their king

Israel's living under the tyranny of the Roman Empire is seen in verses 4 through 6. The children of Israel fell into their neighbors' hand and into the hand of their king. The neighbors mentioned in verse 6 refer to the subordinate kings and governors of the Roman Empire, such as Herod and Pilate, in the region of Palestine. The king in verse 6 is Caesar.

C. Jehovah as Jesus shepherding the afflicted of the flock of Israel

In verses 7 through 11 and 14, we see Jehovah as Jesus shepherding the afflicted of the flock of Israel. Verse 7a says, "I fed the flock of slaughter, and thereby the afflicted of the flock." The I here refers to Jehovah, as indicated by the previous verse. Jehovah as Jesus came to feed His people, who were about to be slaughtered, the afflicted of the flock.

Verses 7b through 11 say, "And I took to myself two staffs; one I called Favor, and the other I called Bonds; and I fed the flock. Then I destroyed the three shepherds in one month; for my soul was impatient with them, and their soul also detested me. Then I said, I will not feed you. What is to die will die, and what is to be destroyed will be destroyed, and those who are left will each eat one another's flesh. And I took my staff, Favor, and I broke it in pieces so as to break my covenant which I had made with all the peoples. And it was broken in that day; and thus the afflicted of the flock, who watched me, knew that it was the word of Jehovah." Here we see that Jehovah as Jesus brought two staffs — Favor and Bonds. Favor means grace, and Bonds means to be bound into oneness. Then Jehovah as Jesus set aside the three shepherds — the priests, the elders, and the scribes. He destroyed them, and their souls detested Him. The Lord Jesus as the proper Shepherd was rejected, leaving the children of Israel as a flock without any shepherd (John 10:11). With respect to Israel's being without a shepherd, Matthew 9:36 says, "Seeing the crowds, He was moved with compassion for them, because they were harassed and cast away like sheep not having a shepherd." Furthermore, He broke the staff, Favor (Zech. 11:10). This indicates that He broke the covenant which God made through Moses, leaving the people without a covenant to cover them. He thus took away the grace (Favor).

Verse 14 goes on to say, "Then I broke my second staff, Bonds, in pieces, so as to break the brotherhood between Judah and Israel." This indicates that the binding love was also taken away. As a result, the nation was divided and full of inner fighting (v. 9). From the day of Christ's crucifixion, there has not been any oneness among the Jews. Although those in the northern kingdom, Israel, and the southern kingdom, Judah, were brothers, the brotherhood among them has been broken because the binding love has been broken. This took place as they were living under the oppression of the Roman Empire.

D. The Messiah, as the proper Shepherd of Israel, being detested, attacked, rejected, and sold for thirty pieces of silver

Zechariah 11:12 and 13 reveal that the Messiah, as the proper Shepherd of Israel, was detested, attacked, rejected, and sold for thirty pieces of silver, the price of a slave (Exo. 21:32). What is prophesied here was fulfilled in the Gospels. The Lord Jesus was sold under the reign of the Roman Empire, and He was judged by the Roman rulers.

Zechariah 11:12 and 13 say, "I said to them, If it is good in your sight, give me my wages; but if not, do not bother. So they weighed out my wages, thirty pieces of silver. And Jehovah said to me, Throw it to the potter, that magnificent price that I am priced with by them. So I took the thirty pieces of silver and threw them to the potter, into the house of Jehovah." This clearly indicates that Christ was detested, attacked, rejected, and sold. In order to understand these verses and know who provided the silver and who threw it into the house of Jehovah, we need to study the four Gospels.

E. The children of Israel being left to the foolish and worthless shepherds

The priests, the elders, and the scribes were all annulled, and Jesus was crucified, rejected to the uttermost. The children of Israel were therefore left to the foolish and worthless shepherds, who would not take care of them (vv. 15-17). This means that after the crucifixion of Christ, there was no proper leadership among them. They fought with one another, devouring one another. The foolish, worthless shepherds who rose up among them caused them further suffering. This kind of situation allowed Titus to come in to devastate the entire country of Judah.

This chapter surely refers to Israel's living under the tyranny of the Roman Empire. The Lord Jesus Himself lived under the reign of the Roman rulers; He lived under the reign of Caesar, the highest ruler, and also under the reign of Herod and Pilate, who were subordinate rulers. Under this reign, He, the real and proper Shepherd, was detested, rejected, attacked, sold, and crucified. Concerning this, Matthew 26:31, a quotation of Zechariah 13:7, says, "I will smite the Shepherd, and the sheep of the flock will be scattered." When Christ, the Shepherd, was put to the cross, all the sheep of His flock were scattered.

Chapters nine through eleven of Zechariah unveil Christ in a very intimate way. The center of the prophecies in these chapters is Christ as the rejected Messiah. In chapter nine Christ came and entered into Jerusalem as the King in a lowly form. Then chapter ten reveals this kind, intimate, and gentle One as the Shepherd coming in His loving visitation to Israel. When He was thirty years of age, He came forth to shepherd the people. During the three and a half years of His ministry on earth, He ministered the spiritual supply to God's chosen people. The time of His ministry was a time of shepherding, and many were helped by His shepherding. However, because His help became so popular, the elders, scribes, and priests became jealous. In their jealousy they arrested Jesus through Judas's betrayal of Him. Following this, He was judged first by the high priest according to God's law and then by the rulers of the Roman government, Herod and Pilate, according to Roman law. The Lord Jesus was altogether justified. Pilate told the Jews that he could not find anything wrong with Jesus (John 18:38; 19:4), but they would not listen to him, and their voices overcame him. "When therefore the chief priests and the attendants saw Him, they cried out, saying, Crucify! Crucify! Pilate said to them, You take Him and crucify Him, for I do not find fault in Him" (John 19:6). Instead of acting justly, Pilate delivered Jesus into the hands of the Jews. They then took Jesus and led Him away to a place called Golgotha, and there they crucified Him. They rejected their King to the uttermost.

The Messiah came in a gentle, intimate way to visit His people Israel as their King. If they had been ready, they would have welcomed Him. Then the kingdom of the heavens would have been set up on earth, and the time of restoration would have come. It should have happened in this way, but because of Israel's rejection of Christ, it did not. If we realize this, then we will understand what is revealed concerning Christ in Zechariah 9—11.

More details regarding Christ are revealed in Zechariah than in Daniel. Daniel mainly reveals that Christ is the One who has gone to God to receive power, authority, and the kingdom. Having received the kingdom, He will come to earth as the smiting stone to smash the great human image, that is, to crush human government entirely. Zechariah intimately unveils Christ as the coming Savior, the coming Redeemer. At first, He was welcomed by the people, but later, under the influence of the elders, priests, and scribes, they changed their mind and detested Him. The Lord Jesus was sold, judged, sentenced, and put on the cross to die. Thus, the Messiah, who was welcomed temporarily, was utterly rejected. As a result, the people of Israel were divided, persecuted by the Roman Empire, and scattered throughout the earth.

The Prophecies of Encouragement

(4)

Scripture Reading: Zech. 12:1-9; 14:1-7, 12-15

The Christ unveiled in the book of Zechariah is a Christ who is intimately involved with human history. The first six chapters reveal that He is involved with the Persian Empire, and the last six chapters reveal that He is involved with the Grecian Empire and the Roman Empire. As we have seen, the center of the prophecies in chapters nine through eleven is Christ as the rejected Messiah. In chapters twelve through fourteen, Christ is unveiled as the Messiah returning to be enthroned as the King not only over Israel but over the whole world. His first coming, described in Zechariah 9—11, was humble and intimate; His coming back, described in Zechariah 12—14, will be with power and authority.

Zechariah 12—14 covers the prophecy concerning Israel's destiny in three matters: in the great war of Armageddon (12:1-9; 14:1-7, 12-15), in their household salvation (12:10—13:9), and in the millennium (14:8-11, 16-21). In this message we will consider the prophecy of encouragement regarding Israel's destiny in the great war of Armageddon. However, first I would like to give a word concerning the significance of the human spirit as revealed in 12:1.

This verse says, "The burden of the word of Jehovah concerning Israel. Thus declares Jehovah, who stretches forth the heavens and lays the foundations of the earth and forms the spirit of man within him." The heavens are for the earth, the earth is for man, and man was created by God with a spirit that he may contact God, receive God, live God, fulfill God's purpose for God, and be one with God. It is marvelous that such a verse as this is in an Old Testament book which unveils a Christ who is so involved with human history and politics. This indicates that in His economy God planned to have Christ as the centrality and universality of His move on earth. As the very God, He has ruled over the entire human race, managing the world situation age after age for thousands of years. For His chosen people, who would care for Him as the Creator and as the Redeemer, there was the need for Him to create a receiver so that they would have the capacity to receive all that God had planned for Christ to be. Christ is wonderful, but if we did not have a spirit, how could we receive Him? Today in every circle of society, people do not exercise their spirit. Even in religious circles, the matter of the human spirit is neglected or even opposed and denied. If we neglect our human spirit, there is no way for us to contact God.

In John 4:24 the Lord Jesus said clearly that God is Spirit and that those who worship Him must worship in spirit. This is the basic principle. To worship God is just to contact God, to receive God, to enjoy God, and to experience God. However, very few among the human race today know that God is a Spirit and that we have been created by God with a spirit. God has ordained that we should contact Him and receive Him by the exercise of our human spirit.

In God's creation there are principles. For instance, if we want to see different colors, we must use our eyes. Suppose I were blind. Could I hear the colors? Could I smell them? Certainly not! In order to see colors, we must use the proper organ. The principle is the same in relation to us and God. God is real, yet some dare to say that there is no God. Of course, if we do not exercise our spirit, surely there is no God to us. We cannot touch God by means of our physical body. Neither can we realize Him by our mentality, by our mind, for this is not the proper organ to use in contacting God. God is Spirit. If we would worship Him, contacting Him and receiving Him, we must exercise our spirit. Thank God that in His creation He made three crucial, equally important matters — the heavens, the earth, and our spirit. Our spirit, therefore, is as crucial, as important, as the heavens and the earth.

Zechariah is a book unveiling Christ as God's center and circumference, yet this Christ is intimately involved with human history. Not just anyone can know this One, but God's chosen people who realize that they have a spirit can know Him. In reading the book of Zechariah and in contacting the Christ revealed in this book, we must first know that we have a spirit. Then we need to exercise our spirit to pray, saying, "Lord, I want to gain the Christ who is unveiled in Zechariah." If we exercise our spirit in this way, we will sense something living touching us deep within. This is why there is in this book such a verse as 12:1, a verse that charges us to pay full attention to the receiver within us, our human spirit, that we may receive the Christ revealed in the book of Zechariah.

God's purpose is for us to receive Christ. However, Christ is complex in all that He is. He is all-inclusive, because He is so many items. Furthermore, this all-inclusive Christ is very involved with history, politics, and governments. How can we understand such a One? The only way is, after reading and studying, to turn ourselves to prayer. When we turn ourselves to prayer, we exercise our spirit. At that moment, Christ imparts Himself into us. This is the heavenly, divine dispensing. Through this dispensing we receive Christ as our life, our light, our patience, our love, our everything.

Though Zechariah was a young man, he knew the secret of contacting God to receive what God has revealed. We all need to learn of him to exercise our spirit to receive God and to receive what He has revealed.

Let us now proceed to consider the prophecy in chapter twelve.

IV. The prophecy concerning Israel's destiny in the great war of Armageddon, in their household salvation, and in the millennium

A. In the great war of Armageddon

Chapters twelve and fourteen show us many aspects of Israel's destiny in the great war of Armageddon.

1. The greatest war among mankind

The war of Armageddon will be the greatest war among mankind. It will terminate human government on earth at the end of the coming great tribulation, in the short period of time that will consummate the present age.

2. A war at the end of the great tribulation

This war will take place at the end of the great tribulation of three and a half years (Matt. 24:21; Dan. 7:25; 12:7; Rev. 11:2; 13:5).

3. A war motivated by Antichrist

The war of Armageddon will be a war motivated by Antichrist to destroy Israel (Rev. 16:12-16; 9:13-16; 19:19).

4. A war waged by Satan through his human followers

Although this war will be motivated by Antichrist, it will be waged by Satan through his human followers against God with His saints (Rev. 16:13-14; 17:14; 19:14; Zech. 14:5b). Satan has his followers, and God has His saints. For thousands of years, Satan has been exercising his devices to gain people for his army. God has also been working to prepare His chosen ones to be His army. Eventually, at the great war of Armageddon, there will be two armies — Satan's earthly army and God's heavenly army.

5. A war fought by Antichrist with his followers directly against Christ with His overcomers

The war of Armageddon will be fought by Antichrist with his followers directly against Christ with His overcomers (11, 14, Rev. 19:19; 17:14). Antichrist, the embodiment of Satan, will be the commander of Satan's army, and Christ, the embodiment of God, will be the Commander of God's army. Thus, on the one hand, it will be a devilish war; on the other hand, it will be a divine war. In this divine war, Christ will destroy Antichrist "by the breath of His mouth" and bring him to nothing "by the manifestation of His coming" (2 Thes. 2:8). These are the weapons Christ will use to defeat Antichrist.

6. A war that will be the great winepress of the fury of God trodden by Christ

This war will be the great winepress of the fury of God trodden by Christ at His coming back to judge the world (Rev. 14:17-20; Isa. 63:1-6). So many evil ones who hate God will join Antichrist in fighting against God. When these evil ones are gathered to Armageddon, they will actually be the grapes to be trodden by God in the winepress of the fury of His wrath. In bringing his armies and so many evil ones together, Antichrist will actually be doing a work for God.

7. The nations that participate being gathered also by Jehovah God

The nations that will participate in that international war against Jerusalem will be gathered also by God. Half of the city of Jerusalem will be brought into captivity, but the rest of the people will not be cut off from the city (Zech. 14:2). In His mercy God will still preserve half of His elect people.

8. Jehovah making Jerusalem a cup of reeling and a burdensome stone to all the besieging peoples

Jehovah will make Jerusalem a cup of reeling and a burdensome stone to all the besieging peoples, that is, to the armies of Antichrist and to all the evil ones with him. God will cause their horses to be bewildered and blind and their riders to be mad (12:2-4). Jerusalem will need divine protection not only against Antichrist and his armies but also against Satan and his demons and evil spirits. We may not know how God will make Jerusalem a cup of reeling and a burdensome stone, but we know that He will do this.

9. Jehovah striking all those who besiege Jerusalem during This war

Jehovah will strike all of them who besiege Jerusalem during the war of Armageddon. Their flesh will rot while they are standing on their feet; their eyes will rot in their sockets; and their tongue will rot in their mouth. A great panic from Jehovah will be among them; and each will seize his neighbor's hand, and his hand will rise up against his neighbor's hand. Furthermore, the wealth of all the surrounding nations will be gathered together, gold and silver and garments in great abundance. The same plague will be on the horse, the mule, the camel, the donkey, and all the cattle that are in those camps (14:12-15).

10. Jehovah of hosts being the strength of the inhabitants of Jerusalem

Jehovah of hosts will be the strength of the inhabitants of Jerusalem and will make the leaders of Judah like a fire pot under wood and like a torch of fire among sheaves, and they will consume all the surrounding peoples on the right and on the left. Jerusalem will dwell again in her own place. Jehovah will save the tents of Judah first and then the house of David and Jerusalem. In that day Jehovah will defend the inhabitants of Jerusalem, making the feeble among them like David and the house of David like God, like the Angel of Jehovah (Christ) before them. (In 12:8 the Angel of Jehovah is in apposition to God.) Moreover, Jehovah will seek to destroy all the nations that come against Jerusalem (12:5-9).

11. Jehovah as Christ coming with His saints

Zechariah 14:3-7 reveals that Jehovah as Christ will then come with His saints and go forth to fight against Satan, embodied in Antichrist, and his followers, the nations.

a. The feet of Jehovah as Christ standing on the Mount of Olives

The feet of Jehovah as Christ will stand in that day on the Mount of Olives, which is before Jerusalem on the east. The Mount of Olives will be split at its middle toward the east and toward the west into a very great valley so that half of the mountain will remove to the north and half of it to the south (v. 4).

b. The remnant of Israel fleeing into the valley of Jehovah's mountains

The remnant of Israel will flee into the valley of Jehovah's mountains (v. 5).

c. In that day there being no light

In that day there will be no light; the shining ones (the sun, the moon, and the stars) will withdraw. It will be a kind of day known only to Jehovah, neither day nor night. But at evening time there will be light (vv. 6-7). This indicates that God will change many things in the universe in order to judge the evil human beings and to save His elect.

The Prophecies of Encouragement

(5)

Scripture Reading: Zech. 12:10-14; 13:1-9

In the previous message we saw Israel's destiny in the great war of Armageddon. In this message we will consider the prophecy of encouragement concerning Israel's household salvation.

B. In their household salvation

1. Hardness coming upon a part of Israel

Romans 11:25b says that a hardness has come upon Israel in part until the fullness of the Gentiles comes in. In the present time, God seemingly has forsaken Israel, and Israel has become somewhat hard. This hardness will continue until the age of the Gentiles has been fulfilled.

2. All Israel to be saved

When the fullness of the Gentiles comes in, all Israel will be saved (Rom. 11:26-27). This will be Israel's household salvation. On the same day and at the same time, thousands of Israelites will be saved.

3. Perhaps taking place while the great war of Armageddon is about to end

It may be that this household salvation of Israel will take place while the great war of Armageddon is about to end (cf. Zech. 14:2-3). At the end of the war of Armageddon, Christ will come to earth, and the remnant of Israel will see Him whom they have pierced, will repent and wail, and will believe in Christ and receive Him (Rev. 1:7; Zech. 12:10). In this way all Israel will be saved. This will be the household salvation rendered to Israel by God.

4. Jehovah God pouring out on the house of David and on the inhabitants of Jerusalem the Spirit of grace and of supplications

Zechariah 12:10a says, "I will pour out on the house of David and on the inhabitants of Jerusalem the Spirit of grace and of supplications; and they will look upon Me, whom they have pierced." In Acts 2 God poured out His Spirit upon all flesh (v. 17), and three thousand were saved. But when God pours out the Spirit of grace upon the inhabitants of Jerusalem, many thousands of Israel, even the entire race of Israel, will be saved.

The Spirit of grace in Zechariah 12:10 is a sweet term, and is in contrast to the Spirit of power in Acts 1:8 and 2:1-4. We should experience the Spirit both as the Spirit of power and as the Spirit of grace. The Spirit of power is to strengthen us, but the Spirit of grace is to bring us into the enjoyment of the Triune God. In Acts 2 there was the participation in the divine power through the Holy Spirit, but there was not that much enjoyment of the Triune God. In Acts 2, at the beginning of the age of grace, the church age, the Spirit was mainly the Spirit of power. But in Zechariah 12, at the ending, the consummation, of the age of grace, the Spirit will be mainly the Spirit of grace for the enjoyment of the Triune God.

By the time of the Lord's second appearing, the remnant of Israel will have suffered all kinds of hardship. They suffered the destruction of Jerusalem in A.D. 70 and were scattered to other countries. In these other countries they continued to suffer persecution. Today most of the Jews remain in dispersion, but many are returning to the nation of Israel. At the time of Antichrist, two-thirds in all the land of Israel will be slaughtered (13:8-9a). Half of the city of Jerusalem will go forth into captivity (14:2). The half which remains will no longer have any taste for human life or for acquiring possessions and high positions. They will realize that they are short of God and will exercise their spirit (12:1), not their mind. At this juncture they will repent, because they have lost their taste for everything. The Holy Spirit will be poured out upon them, and they will follow their spirit to be fully occupied with God. I believe that because they will have learned that everything apart from God is vanity and because they will exercise their spirit, the pouring out of the Spirit of God upon them will be intensified. The Jews on the day of Pentecost were stubborn and hard. Hence, the Spirit of power was poured out to inspire them to repent. But the inhabitants of Jerusalem in Zechariah 12:10 will have already repented; therefore, the Spirit of grace will be poured out upon them so that they can receive the Triune God as their enjoyment.

Zechariah 12:10a also tells us that they will look upon Him whom they have pierced. This means that they will look upon the Christ who was pierced by them. Revelation 1:7a refers to this: "Behold, He comes with the clouds, and every eye will see Him, even those who pierced Him." The piercing of Christ is the foundation of redemption. Apart from Christ's being pierced, there would be no base for our redemption.

The repentant Jews will look upon the One whom they have pierced. Although it was their forefathers who pierced the Lord Jesus, God counts that as something done by these repentant ones. The reason for this is that in the sight of God the entire people of Israel is one person.

a. Wailing over Him with wailing and crying bitterly over Him with bitter crying

Zechariah 12:10b goes on to say, "They will wail over Him with wailing as for an only son and cry bitterly over Him with bitter crying as for a firstborn son." An only son is most dear to his parents, and a firstborn son has honor among the many sons. Repentant Israel will wail over Christ as the only Son of God and will cry bitterly over Him as the firstborn Son of God.

In the New Testament Christ is revealed first as the only begotten Son of God and then as the firstborn Son of God. John 1:18 says that the only begotten Son, who is in the bosom of the Father, has declared Him. John 3:16 tells us that God so loved the world that He gave His only begotten Son. Through His death and resurrection, the only begotten Son became the firstborn Son (Rom. 8:29; Heb. 1:6a). According to the New Testament, Christ's being the only begotten Son is for us to be redeemed and to receive eternal life. Christ's becoming the firstborn Son through death and resurrection is for us to become sons of God as heirs to inherit all the riches of what God is, that is, to receive, participate in, and enjoy all the riches of the Triune God. In their repentance Israel will recognize Christ both as the only begotten Son of God and as the firstborn Son of God. They will realize that as the only begotten Son Christ has redeemed them and has brought them eternal life and that as the firstborn Son He has made them heirs to inherit the riches of the Triune God as their enjoyment.

b. There being great wailing in Jerusalem

In that day there will be great wailing in Jerusalem. The land will wail, every family apart: the family of David and their wives apart; the family of Nathan and their wives apart; the family of Levi and their wives apart; the family of the Shimeites and their wives apart; all the families, the whole household of Israel, that remain (Zech. 12:11-14). Here we have three kinds of families: the royal family of David, the family of the priesthood (Nathan and Levi), and the family of an evil man (Shimei, who cursed David). Zechariah uses these families as illustrations. All those who look upon Christ, the pierced One, with a repentant spirit, will wail over Him.

5. The divine provision and the sovereign preparation for the household salvation of Israel

We come now to Zechariah 13, a chapter on the divine provision and the sovereign preparation for the household salvation of Israel.

a. The divine provision of a redeemer with His redemption

This divine provision includes a Redeemer with His redemption (vv. 1-7a).

1) God providing an opened fountain

God has provided the house of David and the inhabitants of Jerusalem with an opened fountain (Christ's pierced side — John 19:34, 37) for sin and for impurity. "In that day there will be an opened fountain for the house of David and for the inhabitants of Jerusalem, for sin and for impurity" (Zech. 13:1). The piercing of Christ has opened such a fountain. This is a matter of redemption.

2) God cutting off the names of the idols and causing the false prophets and the unclean spirit to pass from the land

God will cut off the names of the idols and will cause the false prophets and the unclean spirit to pass from the land (vv. 2-4). He will clear up these negative things so that the people of Israel might be emptied to receive Christ.

3) Christ coming to be the real prophet but being rejected and wounded in His side in the house of Israel, His relatives in the flesh

Christ came to be the real Prophet (Matt. 13:57) but was rejected and wounded in His side in the house of Israel, His relatives in the flesh (Zech. 13:5-6; 12:10); and the wound became the base of their redemption accomplished for them in His death (John 19:34, 37; Rev. 1:7).

Zechariah 13:5 says, "But He will say, I am no prophet; I am a tiller of the ground; for a man sold Me in My youth." Verses 2 through 4 speak of God's causing the false prophets to pass from the land. This cleared the way for Christ to come in as the real Prophet. However, according to verse 5, He said that He was not a prophet but a tiller of the ground. This means that He was not the kind of prophet, a false prophet, mentioned in the preceding verses. He came as the real Prophet.

Verse 6 goes on to say, "Someone will say to Him, What are these wounds between Your arms? And He will say, Those with which I was wounded in the house of those who love Me." In this verse the phrase "those who love Me" refers to Christ's relatives, the children of Israel. The children of Israel killed Him, but He counted their action as wounds from those who loved Him. This is very sweet.

4) Christ, the fellow of Jehovah, coming as the God-sent Shepherd to the children of Israel but being attacked unto death by them

Christ, the Fellow of Jehovah, came as the God-sent Shepherd to the children of Israel but was attacked unto death by them (v. 7a; Matt. 9:36; John 10:11; Matt. 26:31; Acts 2:23). Zechariah 13:7a says, "Awake, O sword, against My Shepherd, / And against the man who is My Fellow, / Declares Jehovah of hosts. / Strike the Shepherd, / That the sheep may be scattered." Christ was both a relative to the children of Israel and a Fellow of Jehovah. As He was hanging on the cross, His relatives wounded Him, and God called in the sword to strike Him. He was in a situation where His relatives were against Him and where God, to whom He is a Fellow, was also against Him.

The word in verse 7a about striking the Shepherd is quoted by the Lord Jesus in Matthew 26:31. To strike the Shepherd means to attack the Shepherd. Immediately after He established the table, He told His disciples that He would be attacked and that they, the sheep, would be scattered.

b. The sovereign preparation of a people to receive the redeemer with His redemption

In Zechariah 13:7b through 9 we see God's sovereign preparation of a people to receive the Redeemer with His salvation. In His household salvation for Israel, God has provided not only redemption but also a people to receive His redemption. In the same way, God prepared us even before we were born to be recipients of His salvation.

1) God reacting to the rejection of Christ by the children of Israel and turning His hand upon them as the little ones

Verse 7b says, "I will turn My hand upon the little ones." Here the "little ones" refer to the people of Israel. This indicates that in His preparation God reacted to the rejection of Christ by the children of Israel and turned His hand upon them as the little ones by punishing them through Titus the Roman prince and his army in A.D. 70 and scattering them into the nations to be despised, humiliated, persecuted, and destroyed throughout the age of grace until today (Matt. 21:41a; 23:38; 24:2).

2) In the great tribulation two-thirds of them being cut off by Antichrist

In the great tribulation at the consummation of the present age, in all the land of Israel two-thirds of them will be cut off by Antichrist in his persecution of the Jews (Zech. 13:8a; Rev. 11:2; 13:7).

3) One-third of the remnant being left in the land

One-third of the remnant will be left in the land and will be brought through fire and refined like silver and tried like gold by the persecution of Antichrist (Zech. 13:8b-9a). These will be those who are written in the book as the secret record (Dan. 12:1b).

4) They calling on the Lord's name and the Lord answering them

They will call on the Lord's name, and the Lord will answer them. The Lord will say that they are His people, and they will say that the Lord is their God (Zech. 13:9b). They will be saved into the enjoyment of the riches of the Triune God, first in the millennium to be the priests to teach the nations and then in the New Jerusalem to participate in all the blessings God has ordained in eternity and for eternity. This is the household salvation to Israel.

The Prophecies of Encouragement

(6)

Scripture Reading: Zech. 14:8-11, 16-21

The center of the prophecies in chapters twelve through fourteen is Christ as the rejected Messiah coming back to be enthroned. In the two foregoing messages we considered the prophecy concerning Israel's destiny in the great war of Armageddon and in their household salvation. In this message we will first consider the prophecy of encouragement concerning Israel's destiny in the millennium and then make a comparison of two main categories of things in the books of Daniel and Zechariah. Following this, I would like to give a word concerning our need to be brought into the realm of God's economy.

C. In the millennium

1. Living Waters Going Forth from Jerusalem

In the millennium there will be no thirst. Living waters will go forth from Jerusalem, half of them toward the eastern sea, the Dead Sea, and half of them toward the western sea, the Mediterranean Sea (14:8). This is similar to the record in the book of Ezekiel concerning the living water flowing out of the temple of God (Ezek. 47:1-2).

2. Jehovah as Christ being King over all the earth

In the millennium Jehovah as Christ will be King over all the earth, and He will be the one God and His name the one name (Zech. 14:9).

3. Jerusalem being raised up and dwelling in her place

Jerusalem will be raised up and will dwell in her place (v. 10).

4. People dwelling in Jerusalem, and there being no more curse

People will dwell in Jerusalem, and there will be no more curse, for Jerusalem will dwell securely (v. 11). Instead of curse, there will be blessing with security.

5. Everyone left from all the nations that went forth against Jerusalem going up from year to year to worship the King, Jehovah of hosts, and to keep the Feast of Tabernacles

Everyone left from all the nations that went forth against Jerusalem will go up from year to year to worship the King, Jehovah of hosts, and to keep the Feast of Tabernacles (v. 16). Whoever does not go up to Jerusalem to worship the King, Jehovah of hosts, upon them there will be no rain, but there will be the plague with which Jehovah strikes the nations. This will be their sin (vv. 17-19). Because the present age is the age of grace, God sends rain on the just and the unjust alike (Matt. 5:45). But the coming age will be the age of righteousness. Those who do not go up to Jerusalem to worship the King and to keep the Feast of Tabernacles will not receive rain. This is righteous.

6. Holiness to Jehovah of hosts

In the millennium, on the horses' bells will be, "Holiness to Jehovah"; and the pots in the house of Jehovah will be like the basins before the altar (Zech. 14:20). The pots are something small, and the basins are something large. But in the millennium the pots in the house of God will be as large as the basins before the altar. Indeed every pot in Jerusalem and Judah will be holiness to Jehovah of hosts; and all those who sacrifice will come and take of them and boil in them; and there will never again be a Canaanite (or, merchant) in the house of Jehovah of hosts in that day (v. 21). This is Israel's destiny in the millennium.

A comparison of two main categories of things in the books of Daniel and Zechariah

Let us now go on to make a comparison of two main categories of things in the books of Daniel and Zechariah.

I. Of the things concerning human government

A. In the book of Daniel

In Daniel the great human image signifies the entire human government on earth as a skeleton (ch. 2). The four beasts from the Mediterranean Sea give a sketch of human government on earth (ch. 7). A ram and a male goat with its successors give a sketch of the Persian Empire and the Grecian Empire with its successors, ending with the one, Antiochus Epiphanes, who is the first type of Antichrist (ch. 8). The king of the south and the king of the north give a record of the wars between the successors of the Grecian Empire, ending with Antiochus Epiphanes, the first type of Antichrist (ch. 11). The seventy weeks give a sketch of the destiny of Israel, from the return from their captivity to the consummation of the present age, ending with Antichrist (ch. 9).

B. In the book of Zechariah

In Zechariah the prophecy concerning the nations around Judah in relation to Israel gives some details of the Grecian Empire's invasion into the holy land and the defeat of its successor by the heroic Jews (ch. 9). The prophecy concerning the living of Israel under the oppression of the Roman Empire gives some details about the living under the tyranny of the Roman Empire (ch. 11). The prophecy concerning Israel's destiny in the great war of Armageddon gives the details of how human government, signified by the great human image in Daniel 2, will be destroyed in its final part, signified by the toes of the great human image (chs. 12, 14).

II. Of the things concerning Christ

A. In the book of Daniel

The book of Daniel reveals certain crucial things concerning Christ. According to 9:26, the crucifixion of Christ, the Messiah, was the termination of the old creation and the germination of God's new creation in His resurrection. In 10:4-9 we see the appearing of the excellent Christ, the centrality and universality of God's move on earth, to Daniel for his appreciation, consolation, encouragement, expectation, and stabilization. Daniel 7:13-14 unveils the coming of Christ as the Son of Man with the eternal dominion, glory, and kingdom given to Him by the Ancient of Days, that all the peoples, nations, and languages might serve Him. Finally, Daniel speaks regarding the appearing of Christ as the stone cut out without hands to strike the great human image to terminate the entire human government on earth and become a great mountain, signifying the eternal kingdom of God filling the whole earth (2:34-35).

B. In the book of Zechariah

The book of Zechariah reveals many things concerning Christ. First, the redeeming Christ, as a man and as the Angel of Jehovah, the embodiment of the Triune God, was sent by God to be with His humiliated people of Israel in their captivity, signified by the myrtle trees in the bottoms (1:8-11). Then Christ, as a man in His humanity, was the One sent by Jehovah of hosts and was also the Sender, Jehovah of hosts, dealing with the nations who plundered the people of Zion and touched them as touching the pupil of His eye (2:1, 8-10).

Following this, Christ was the Servant of Jehovah and the Shoot to be the stone with seven eyes engraved by God for the removing of the iniquity of the holy land for the building of the temple of God (3:8-9). Christ was also the topstone of grace for the completion of the building of the temple of God (4:7-9). Christ as the Shoot for the building of the temple of God will bear majesty and will sit and rule on His throne as a Priest and as a King (6:12-13).

Christ as the King of Israel came into Jerusalem lowly and riding upon a donkey, even upon a colt (9:9), yet Christ as the Shepherd of God's elect was rejected and sold at the price of a slave, thirty pieces of silver (11:12-13). Christ as God's Fellow was the God-sent Shepherd, but He was attacked unto death (13:7).

At His coming, Christ will appear to the children of Israel as their Redeemer and Savior, the One who was pierced by them, and they will look upon Him and wail over Him (12:10). Christ came as the real Prophet, but He was rejected and wounded by Israel, who were His relatives, to make the base for their salvation and an open fountain for their sin and their iniquity (13:5-6, 1).

At the end of this age, Christ will come to stand on the Mount of Olives and will fight with the nations that besiege Jerusalem (14:3-4). Then Christ as Jehovah will be King over all the earth in the millennium (v. 9).

The Christ unveiled in Zechariah, the pierced One with whom there is the open fountain, is the centrality and universality of God's economy. As such a One, He is intimately involved with human history, in particular with the Persian Empire, the Grecian Empire, and the Roman Empire. The Roman Empire especially has been helpful to Christ. Christ was born under the Roman Empire. Without the Roman Empire, it would not have been possible for Christ to be born. He grew up, carried out His ministry, was crucified, resurrected, and ascended under the Roman Empire. Christ's death for the accomplishment of God's eternal redemption was consummated under the Roman Empire. The formation of the church and the preaching of the gospel also took place under the Roman Empire. Surely, the Roman Empire, whose influence in law and culture continues today, has been used by God to fulfill His intention to make Christ the centrality and universality of His economy.

A word concerning our need to be brought into the realm of God's economy

At this point I would like to say a word concerning our need to be brought into the realm of God's economy.

Most Christians consider the Bible to be a book which teaches them to be good, ethical, godly, and spiritual. This is not wrong; it is right and good. But this is only for their own benefit; this is not at all for God. Teaching people to be good, moral, ethical, godly, and spiritual is only a minor point in the Bible. The major point in the Bible concerns God's economy, yet in Christianity today nearly no one talks about God's economy. The books of Isaiah, Daniel, and Zechariah are on Christ, not only as our Savior, Redeemer, and Deliverer but also as the centrality and universality of God's move to fulfill His economy on earth. Outside the Lord's recovery, where can you hear such a word? Because hardly anyone cares for God's economy, the Lord has been delayed for nearly two thousand years. The world situation is ready for the Lord Jesus to come back, but what about God's economy?

The center of God's economy is to have a Body to express Christ. Eventually, this Body will be Christ's bride to match Him as His counterpart and to come down to earth with Him to carry out the final step of God's economy. Today, the world situation is ready for His coming, but the Lord has not yet gained His counterpart. Therefore, He has no way to come back. He is still waiting.

Throughout the centuries, the Lord has been continually working through those who love Him to recover the lost truths. But because of their dullness, the Lord has had to move quite slowly. Martin Luther was strong concerning justification by faith, a basic item, but not concerning the church practice. Following Luther, the mystics were used by God to recover the inner life, and with Zinzendorf and his companions there was the recovery of the practice of the church life in an initial way. Later, in the nineteenth century, God used the Brethren to recover the practice of the church life in a much fuller way. However, they soon became degraded. Therefore, early in this century the Lord did something in China to gain the recovery of the church life in a full way. Now the recovery in this full sense has come to us.

I am concerned that the dear saints who have been brought into the Lord's recovery have mainly received help first in the assurance of salvation and then in such matters as godliness, ethics, spirituality, and overcoming. All these things are very good. Nevertheless, I do not believe that many among us in the Lord's recovery are clear about God's economy. God's economy is to dispense Christ into His elect that they might become first the Body of Christ to express Him and then the bride of Christ to match Him and fulfill God's economy in the divine dispensing. Of course, I am happy that so many have come to receive help to seek God, to seek Christ, to grow in life, and to be more godly, more spiritual, and more overcoming, but I am not satisfied with this. I would rather that we all had the eyes to see God's economy. My intention, my goal, in all these messages is to help you to advance beyond the realm of seeking for spirituality into another realm to see God's desire, God's good pleasure.

According to His eternal arrangement, or economy, God desires to have the church, a proper church in the biblical sense. Christianity is a totality of organization, but the church revealed in the Bible should be absolutely organic and full of Christ as life, full of the Triune God in His consummation — the all-inclusive life-giving Spirit — to constitute us with God's life and nature and to join us with God as one spirit. This is God's economy through His dispensing.

Today in Christianity, even among the most spiritual ones, what is taught is not food but sugar. That kind of teaching harms you more than it nourishes you. If you read these messages for the purpose merely to receive help to be more seeking after God, more seeking after Christ, and to grow in life, even this is in the realm of sugar. You need solid food (Heb. 5:11-14). Whereas milk is for babes, solid food is for the mature. Among the millions of Christians today, who is not a babe? We have been carrying out the life-study of the Scriptures now for seventeen years, yet most of the saints are still remaining, lingering, wandering, in the realm of being spiritual, victorious, overcoming, and so forth. Very few, even among the co-workers, are qualified to give a message on God's economy with the divine dispensing. We need to be brought into another realm, not the so-called spiritual realm but the realm of God's economy, God's dispensing. I will not be satisfied until I see this. I am somewhat happy that the Lord has released all these truths among us, and I have the full faith and assurance that all these things will eventually be realized; yet I long to see their fulfillment.

A Word Concerning the Human Spirit and the Christ Unveiled in Zechariah

Scripture Reading: Zech. 12:1; Isa. 42:5-6; John 4:24; 2 Tim. 4:22; Zech. 3:9; Rev. 5:6; Zech. 1:8-11, 20-21; 2:1-2, 5, 8-9, 11; 2:3, 4:7, 4:9, 11-14; 9:9; 11:7-13; 14:9, 16-17; 1, 6:12-15

The book of Zechariah reveals that Christ is wonderful and that He is the centrality and universality of God's economy. But how can we receive such a Christ? The means and the instrument by which we can receive Christ is our human spirit. In this message, therefore, I would like to give a word concerning the human spirit and the Christ unveiled in Zechariah.

Sister verses in Zechariah and Isaiah

In the books of Zechariah and Isaiah, both of which have much to say about Christ, there are sister verses that speak clearly regarding the human spirit. Zechariah 12:1 says, "Thus declares Jehovah, who stretches forth the heavens and lays the foundations of the earth and forms the spirit of man within him." This reveals that the heavens are for the earth, the earth is for man, and man was created by God with a spirit that he may contact God, receive God, live God, fulfill God's purpose for God, and be one with God.

Isaiah 42:5 is a sister verse to Zechariah 12:1. "Thus says God Jehovah, / Who created the heavens and stretched them out, / Who spread forth the earth and what springs up from it, / Who gives breath to the people upon it / And spirit to those who walk on it." The Hebrew word translated breath here can also be rendered spirit (cf. Prov. 20:27). These sister verses both mention three matters: the heavens, the earth, and the human spirit. Whereas Zechariah 12:1 speaks of God's forming the human spirit, Isaiah 42:5 simply speaks of God's giving a spirit to man.

Verse 6 goes on to speak concerning God's purpose in giving man a spirit. "I am Jehovah; I have called You in righteousness; / I have held You by the hand; / I have kept You and I have given You / As a covenant for the people, as a light for the nations." Here we see that God intends to give His Son Christ to us as a covenant and as a light to the nations. Such a Christ is wonderful, but unless we can receive Him, He does not have anything to do with us. In order to receive this Christ, we must have a receiver within us, and this receiver is our human spirit. God has given us a spirit so that we can receive, partake of, participate in, and enjoy Christ as the covenant and as the light.

Worshipping God in Spirit

At this point I would like to remind you of the Lord's conversation with the Samaritan woman in John 4. The Lord Jesus said to her, "Whoever drinks of the water that I will give him shall by no means thirst forever; but the water that I will give him will become in him a spring of water gushing up into eternal life" (v. 14). When she asked Him to give her this water, He told her to go and call her husband (vv. 15-16). His intention was to help her to know her sins. However, she immediately turned the conversation to the matter of worship, saying, "Our fathers worshipped in this mountain, yet you say that in Jerusalem is the place where men must worship" (v. 20). The Lord Jesus replied, "An hour is coming when neither in this mountain nor in Jerusalem will you worship the Father....But an hour is coming, and it is now, when the true worshippers will worship the Father in spirit and truthfulness...God is Spirit, and those who worship Him must worship in spirit and truthfulness" (vv. 21, 23-24). John 4:24, a wonderful verse, matches Zechariah 12:1 and Isaiah 42:5.

In His word to the Samaritan woman, the Lord Jesus seemed to be saying, "Woman, you do not know what it is to worship God. The real worship of God is not on a mountain or in Jerusalem — it is in your spirit. Only by using your spirit can you touch God. I am your God, and I am here as living water for you to drink of Me. The way to drink this living water is to exercise your spirit. This is what it means to worship the Father." God has given us a spirit that we may worship Him by drinking of Him.

The Lord being with our spirit

Another crucial verse concerning the human spirit is 2 Timothy 4:22. "The Lord be with your spirit. Grace be with you." This verse does not say that the Lord is with our mind or soul or heart; it tells us that He is with our spirit. Deep within, in the center of our being, we have a particular organ — the human spirit — created by God for the purpose of receiving Him and containing Him. We all, especially the young people, need to see that today the Lord Jesus Christ is with our spirit.

Our spirit and the sevenfold intensified Spirit

Our regenerated human spirit matches Christ, who is the Spirit (2 Cor. 3:17). Regarding this, Zechariah 3:9 says, "This is the stone that I have set before Joshua: upon one stone are seven eyes. Behold, I will engrave its engraving, declares Jehovah of hosts, and I will remove the iniquity of that land in one day." This stone which has been engraved with God's engraving to take away the sin of God's people is Christ. The seven eyes of the stone are "the eyes of Jehovah running to and fro on the whole earth" (4:10). In order to understand the significance of the seven eyes, we need to consider Revelation 5:6. "I saw...a Lamb standing as having just been slain, having seven horns and seven eyes, which are the seven Spirits of God sent forth into all the earth." The Lamb here, who is the stone in Zechariah 3:9, is Christ, and the seven eyes are the sevenfold intensified Spirit. Thus, the Christ who has been engraved by God to take away our sin bears the sevenfold intensified Spirit. Actually, He, the last Adam, has become a life-giving Spirit (1 Cor. 15:45b), even the sevenfold intensified Spirit. Christ today is the Spirit, and we have a spirit particularly formed by God to match Christ.

Let us now go on to consider the Christ who is unveiled in the book of Zechariah. In the first part of this book (chs. 1—6), there are five visions concerning Christ, and in the last part (chs. 9—14), many details concerning Christ.

Visions concerning Christ

In the first of the five visions concerning Christ, Christ is unveiled as the Man as the Angel of Jehovah riding on a red horse and standing among the myrtle trees (1:7-17). The myrtle trees signify the humiliated yet precious people of Israel in their captivity. Christ's riding on a red horse indicates that He was the redeeming One. His being the Angel of Jehovah indicates that He was the One sent by God to take care of His people with much expectation while they were in captivity.

In the second vision (vv. 20-21) Christ is the last Craftsman used by God to break the four horns — Babylon, Persia, Greece, and the Roman Empire — which damaged and destroyed the chosen people of God (vv. 18-19). Christ will be the unique One not only to break the four horns but also to smash the entire human government from the toes to the head, as signified by the great human image in Daniel 2.

In the next vision Christ is the One who measures Jerusalem in order to possess it (Zech. 2:1-2). This One not only possesses Jerusalem but also becomes the center of Jerusalem as the glory within her and the circumference of Jerusalem as the wall of fire round about her (v. 5). Furthermore, He is both the sending One and the sent One. He, Jehovah of hosts, has sent Himself as the Angel of Jehovah (vv. 8-9, 11).

In the fourth vision Christ is unveiled as the topstone of grace (4:7). As indicated in 3:9, upon this stone are seven eyes, signifying the seven Spirits, that is, the sevenfold intensified Spirit. Christ is therefore the topstone of grace to consummate God's building with the sevenfold intensified Spirit.

The fifth vision involving Christ is the vision of the lampstand of gold and the two olive trees (4:2-3, 11-14). The lampstand here signifies the nation of Israel as the collective testimony of God shining out all His virtues. We may say that this lampstand is also a type of Christ, the embodiment of the Triune God. In Zechariah's time the two olive trees were Joshua and Zerubbabel, but during the three and a half years of the great tribulation, the two olive trees will be Moses and Elijah.

Details concerning Christ

The last six chapters of Zechariah are divided into two groups: chapters nine through eleven, which speak of Christ's lowly first coming, and chapters twelve through fourteen, which speak of Christ's victorious second coming.

In His first coming

In His first coming, Christ came as a lowly King and was temporarily welcomed as the King into Jerusalem in a lowly form. Regarding this, 9:9 says, "Exult greatly, O daughter of Zion; / Shout, O daughter of Jerusalem! / Now your King comes to you. / He is righteous and bears salvation; / Lowly and riding upon a donkey, / Even upon a colt, the foal of a donkey." Christ came also as a Shepherd (11:7-11), shepherding in Favor (grace) and Bonds (binding). However, He, the proper Shepherd of Israel, was detested, attacked, rejected, and sold for thirty pieces of silver (vv. 12-13). The children of Israel were thus left to false, useless, and worthless shepherds — the elders, the priests, and the scribes — who would not take care of them (v. 17).

In His second coming

In chapters twelve through fourteen, we see Christ in His second coming. In His coming back, He will be the King not only over Israel but also over all the peoples on earth. "Jehovah will be King over all the earth; and in that day Jehovah will be the one God and His name the one name" (14:9). He will reign over the entire earth, and all the peoples of the earth will go up to Jerusalem from year to year to worship the King, Jehovah of hosts, and to keep the Feast of Tabernacles (v. 16). Upon those who refuse to go up to Jerusalem to worship the King, there will be no rain (v. 17).

Christ and the temple of God

The book of Zechariah clearly reveals that God desires the rebuilding of the temple (4:9; 6:12-15). However, without Christ everything, including the temple, is empty. We need Christ, yet Christ needs a Body. This Body is the temple of God, the house of God, the expression of God, the satisfaction of God. Hence, today we should emphasize both Christ and the church. Concerning Christ, we need to pay attention both to the crucial aspects unveiled in chapters one through six and to the details unveiled in chapters nine through fourteen.

Christ's judgment upon three categories of things

Finally, I would like to point out that in the book of Zechariah we can see Christ's judgment. The vision of the flying scroll (5:1-4), the vision of the ephah vessel (vv. 5-11), and the vision of the four chariots (6:1-8) are visions of judgment. Christ's judgment will be carried out by the four chariots which come forth from between two mountains of brass (v. 1). Brass here signifies judgment. Although the two mountains of brass do not signify Christ, they are nevertheless closely related to Christ, for He has been appointed by God to carry out the judgment upon the living and the dead (John 5:22; Acts 10:42; 17:31; 2 Tim. 4:1). On the one hand, Christ is the Redeemer and the Savior; on the other hand, He is the Judge. As the Judge, He will carry out God's judgment.

According to Zechariah, Christ's judgment over the earth will be upon three categories of negative things. First, He will judge stealing (5:3b, 4b). Stealing signifies sins toward man, which are the issue of greed and covetousness. Second, Christ will judge the matter of swearing falsely by Jehovah's name (vv. 3c, 4c). Swearing falsely by Jehovah's name signifies sins toward God, which are the issue of a wrong relationship with God. Those who swear falsely in this way do not deal with God in faithfulness and honesty. Third, Christ will judge the entire human government signified by the great human image in Daniel 2. He, the last Craftsman, will come as the stone cut out without hands and smash this great image from the toes to the head. Thus, He will clear away from the earth all stealing, all false swearing by Jehovah's name, and all of human government.

We need to see how Christ's judgment is related to us today. We should be careful not to steal from others in any way, and we should also be careful to be honest and faithful with God. Then we will be right with man and also right with God. Finally, we need to see that Christ will come as the stone cut out without hands and will smash the entire human government and thereby bring in the eternal kingdom of God.